

Song of Songs: A Translation and Commentary

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Dedicated to Becky Brown, beautiful in appearance as well as in heart

Preface

Should You Read This Commentary?

This commentary has been written in the hopes that its contents will be appropriate for well-grounded Christians,¹ whether married or unmarried. True, it does contain some discussion of sex. But this is because Song of Songs²—no less a part of the Bible than Romans is—addresses that topic. I have tried to follow the biblical model for talking about sexual matters in this commentary—that is, in a direct, but gentle, manner. If you are someone who struggles mightily with sexual sins, you may find it wise to pray and seek counsel from others before deciding to read this commentary, so as to make no provision for the lusts of the flesh (Rom 13:14). If you are a child, I would suggest that you ask your parents to look at this commentary and then to decide whether or not it would be best for you to read it. But with these caveats in mind, the following pages should be appropriate for all believers.

The Purposes of this Commentary

Perhaps no other book of the Bible is as difficult for Americans to understand and to appreciate. To varying extents, Christians from other parts of the modern world will experience overlapping difficulties with the book. The primary purpose of this commentary, then, is to clarify various portions of the book—both as to the meaning and as to the tenor intended by the author. The secondary purpose of this commentary is to offer some thoughts and applications to both married and unmarried Christians.

¹ If you are not presently a believer in Jesus Christ as the one and only savior from the penalty of your sin, I do hope that the commentary will be of benefit, since it points to some of the beauties and joys inherent in that worldview which recognizes the God described in Christian Scripture as the creator of all things. If you are interested in learning more about Jesus Christ and what he calls and invites humankind to, I would direct your attention especially to the biblical book known as “The Gospel of John.”

² Also known as “Song of Solomon,” but “Song of Songs” is the title intended by its author (1:1).

Format of the Commentary

This commentary includes three basic components. First, an introduction addresses various topics. I have tried to be brief, but some readers might wish to skip straight to the translation.

Second, there is a translation,³ which is broken into sections. (My translation of the entire book, uninterrupted by commentary, can be found in Appendix 8.) For convenience, I have broken the verses into lines and added letters to the traditional verse numbers.⁴ Brackets enclose material I have supplied to clarify things—including to identify who I believe the speaker is.⁵ Above each translated section there is a brief interpretive summary (printed in italics) of the following material.

Third, following each section of the translation is the commentary. The commentary is itself grouped under three headings:

- (1) “Clarifying the Ideas”: This material will aim to show the logic of the passage and to clear up potential misunderstandings arising from cultural differences between ancient Israel and the modern United States.
 - (2) “Notes on Some Details”: This material will handle more technical matters. Some readers might wish to skip over these portions of the commentary.
 - (3) “Considering the Message”: This material will offer reflections on the significance of the passage, and some will offer some suggestions for applying the text to daily life.
- Bold words indicate words quoted directly from the passage being discussed.

Introduction

Introduction, Part 1: Ancient Culture and Song of Songs

Proverbs 28:25 says, “A greedy man stirs up strife, but the one who trusts in the LORD will be enriched (ESV).” When we learn that the literal translation of the last word of this verse is actually “made fat,” this hardly sounds like a good outcome for the man who trusts in the Lord. No one wants to be fat! But our American ears are deceiving us. Being noticeably skinny was something an ancient Israelite would have found neither desirable nor something indicative of good health. In that culture, being skinny implied probably illness or grinding poverty. Certainly, Prov 28:25 is not condoning overindulgence; gluttony is something the Bible elsewhere condemns. But it is evident that Israelite culture approached the matter of body weight—or at least how to talk about it—differently than American culture does.

This example is just one of many. Similar cultural matters are common in the Bible. And they occur quite frequently in the Song of Songs, short though the book is. (Romance is cross-cultural, but how it is expressed is apparently significantly culturally defined.) When Americans are bewildered by this book, much of the confusion has to do with cultural misunderstandings. The notes that accompany the translation—especially those in the “Clarifying the Ideas” sections—will attempt to clarify some of these cultural differences.

Introduction, Part 2: Authorship of the Book

Scholars have traditionally identified King Solomon as the author of this book. There are problems with Solomonic authorship of this book, and the personal name given in 1:1 can be translated instead as “Shalmah” (a woman's name)—my preferred approach (for discussion, see Appendix 1). That said, I will ordinarily refer in this commentary to “the author,” leaving the question open.⁶

Introduction, Part 3: Literary Features

To give a taste of the artistry of the poet, I will mention here a few (but only a few) of the techniques the author uses to make the message of the book beautiful and memorable.

³ The Hebrew text being translated is that of Brown (see the “Works Cited” section), albeit updated at 7:10.

⁴ The original Hebrew did not have line breaks or verses; these are a later invention for ease of reference. (In general, the line breaks of the translation follow what I take to be the meter of the Hebrew, but I have taken some liberties for the sake of smooth English.)

⁵ At times the grammar of the Hebrew original makes it pretty clear who the speaker is, but at other times the reader must make an educated guess.

⁶ This practice also has the advantage of maintaining a distinction between Solomon as the possible author of the book and Solomon as a character within the story.

1. *Twice and Thrice*: There are several snatches of poetry which (allowing for slight variations) the author uses two times across the book, for example:

“I am love-sick” (2:5, 5:8)

“Until the day breathes” (2:17, 4:6)

Likewise, there are elements that the author uses three times across the book, for example:

“Most beautiful among women” (1:8, 5:9, 6:1)

“Be like a gazelle or young stag” (2:9, 17, 8:4)

“I am my beloved's” (2:16, 6:3, 7:10)

There are many more cases like these. As mentioned, the wording is not always precisely the same. Furthermore, they do not occur at regular intervals, so they are not musical choruses (at least not in a way that modern American music would recognize). Thus frequent, yet apparently unpatterned, repetition is one of the tools in the author's artistic kit. As one reads through the poem, the reader experiences a sense of familiarity (the book seems almost to have its own voice, just as one's friends may recognize in him or her characteristic turns of phrase) but not monotony. The poet's technique may be compared to a film score in which various musical motifs recur and interact at not-quite-predictable intervals; or to a well-designed living space in which various colors and motifs repeat themselves in ways that are cohesive but not confining.

2. *Poetry*: It is vital to remember that Song of Songs is poetry, not prose. The poetic nature of the book entails a number of things. For instance, in poetry there is a verbal artistry in which matters of sound (rhythm, alliteration, etc.) synergize with meanings of words. (As an example, in 1:3 the Hebrew words for “oil” and “name” sound similar, as do the words “for that reason” and “the young women.”) Much of this artistry sadly vanishes in the transfer of the basic meaning from Hebrew to English, but some of it remains: Perhaps most notably, most Hebrew poetry (many scholars would say “all”) employs parallelism, wherein a thought is packaged in two (or sometimes three) lines, stating a thought in the first line, and then restating it, developing it, or stating its opposite (in Hebrew, the parallel lines will have the same, or nearly the same, number of words as the first line). Another thing to note about the poetic tradition is non-literal language. To take a fairly obvious example, in 2:15 we see the couple trying to avoid some problems, but the problem is not small, red or gray animals with fluffy tails, even though the word “foxes” is used. The problems are small but elusive—and if left unchecked, potentially ruinous—like foxes (at least if one is, for example, a chicken farmer). To take a less obvious example, the “Daughters of Jerusalem” are probably not to be taken literally as a group of people awkwardly following the couple around, but rather as a poetic device for bringing to the readers' attention certain things that would not otherwise be natural for the main characters to say.

3. *Insider Perspective*: Apart from the book title (1:1), Song of Songs speaks only through the voices of characters.⁷ Everything is “I” or “we,” not “he,” “she,” or “they” (except when one character is talking about another). This approach, it is true, can make the book difficult to understand at times, especially as the Hebrew offers no headings to alert the reader to a change in speaker (though at times Hebrew grammar clears things up). Yet the author judged this difficulty a price worth paying, for allowing the characters full reign gives their feelings and reactions an immediacy that mere reports could never offer. “The power of the Song lies in its ability to draw us into the experience of the couple... In the process we learn significant things about how the one-flesh relationship that God designed is supposed to work” (Curtis, 119).

Introduction, Part 4: The Characters in the Book

There are between three and four main characters (or character sets).

1. *The Daughters of Jerusalem*: This group of young women makes regular appearances, appearances that can be so sudden that I suspect this group ought not to be taken too literally. At any rate, theirs is a support role. At times (e.g., 1:4b) they offer confirmation that the qualities of the bride or groom are observable by the wider community, not merely figments of the imagination. (Love-struck individuals can, after all, imagine the object of their affection to be a great deal more worthy of admiration than is actually the case.) At times (e.g. 5:9), they give one of the main characters an opportunity to affirm their admiration for and commitment to their bride or groom (5:9, 7:1). Indeed, they seem to offer a constructive

⁷ Possible exceptions include 3:6, 5:1 (the last line), 6:10, 8:5, and 3:7-11, but the first four of these passages can be ascribed to the Daughters of Jerusalem, and 3:7-11 can be ascribed to the bride (see the commentary there).

role in mending fractures in the relationship (2:15).

2. *The Wife*:⁸ The wife is the first to speak (1:2), and the last (8:14). In a culture where wives were often viewed as mere tools (to acquire sons, etc.), we find a book in which a woman is central to the story, has a developed personality, and at times asserts herself. Early on she is insecure about her appearance (1:6), yet she grows in confidence (7:10). In approximately the middle of the poem, a difficult time in their marriage comes (5:3), yet the wife does not allow that time to define their story (5:8). She demands appropriate commitment from her husband (8:6), and offers the same to him (8:12). She comes from a poor, hard-working family (1:6); what attracted her husband to her was her strong moral character (8:10). The wife is never given a name (though she is once referred to as a Shulammite; see on 6:13), probably to avoid the impression that Song of Songs is a historical work detailing the life of some particular woman. Instead, this woman is a character crafted so as to invite every married woman to see herself in her. Of course, everyone is different, so different elements of Song of Songs will stand out to different people (and different elements of the book might stand out to the same person at different points in life).

3. *The Husband*: Some elements of the identity and background of the groom are difficult to establish (for reasons we will discuss in the next paragraph). But much can be said: He is a man with a good reputation in the community (1:3), he is generous (2:4), and he is unstinting in his praise for his wife (much of the book is taken up with his enthrallment with her).

4. *Solomon*: Conservative scholars have often assumed that the groom/husband in this book is none other than King Solomon. There is much to be said for this assumption: Solomon might be the author (as discussed under “Authorship of the Book” above), his name is mentioned several other times (3:7, 9, 11, 8:11, 12),⁹ and in three cases the groom is referred to as “the king” (1:4, 12, 7:6). Even so, there are good reasons to think that Solomon is *not* the groom. Solomon, rather, is quite unlike the husband, for the king of Israel had countless women (6:8), while the bride is unafraid to expect fidelity from her husband (8:6). The wedding procession in 3:7-11 might be a literary foil, a contrast between a proud monarch's longing for public praise and a loving groom's zeal to praise his bride. The wife mentions Solomon in 8:11-12, it seems to me, not to commit herself to him but to scorn his money, her own love not being for sale (8:7b). The use of “king” for the groom might be affectionate, rather than literal (see “Clarifying the Ideas” on 1:4). Also, if the name of the groom is “Solomon,” it is strange that his name is mentioned so few times. If one assumes Solomonic authorship of Song of Songs, it might be objected that Solomon would not have cast himself in such a negative light. But it is hard to prove that, at least in his better moments, he would not do just that; indeed, if he wrote Ecclesiastes,¹⁰ he proves quite willing to offer quite unflattering portraits of his behavior. Certainly in the book of Proverbs Solomon implicitly criticizes his behavior toward women (Pr 5:16). I think, then, that Solomon's role as a character (as opposed to his role as the author, if he is the author) is to highlight the virtues of the wife and husband by exhibiting an unsavory alternative approach to marriage.¹¹

Concerning the absence of references to God in the Song of Songs, see the last paragraph of Appendix 7.

Introduction, Part 5: Are (And When Are) the Two Main Characters Married to Each Other?

While it is true that there are no unequivocal statements in Song of Songs that the two main characters are married to each other (Fox xii), the basic question of their marital status can be answered by (1) the tenor of

⁸ Another apt designation for this character might be “bride,” while the next character could be referred to as the “groom”: There is a degree of ambiguity in the English words “bride” and “groom” which could be capitalized upon: While normally these terms are used of a woman a man not yet (but soon to be) wed, they are used, at times, for people who are recently married, or as terms of endearment by a spouse. Since in portions of Song of Songs some period of the engagement or wedding might be being depicted or reminisced about, and since there is a great deal of affection on display, these words could be deemed helpful. In the end, however, the English terms “bride” and “groom” are probably too often used to refer specifically to the marriage ceremony (or to events leading up to it) to be more useful than confusing. Moreover, it is the position of this commentary that the couple is married for the entirety of the book, rather than becoming wed part way through (see “Are the Two Main Characters Married to Each Other?”).

⁹ Concerning 1:5 see the “Notes on Some Details” section there.

¹⁰ Such is a widely held view, but the book does not explicitly identify its author.

¹¹ If I am wrong, and Solomon actually is the groom in this book, perhaps Solomon's intent is to portray himself as the man he ought to have been, not as the man he actually was.

the book as a whole combined with (2) other passages of Scripture. As to the first point, granting that there is much uncertainty about the details, it is all but certain that the book alludes at times to sexual activity between the main characters. As to the second point, the Bible elsewhere makes clear that sex outside of marriage is a grave sin (1 Cor 6:18-19, Heb 13:4). The only reasonable inference is that the main characters in Song of Songs are indeed married when they engage in sexual activity. (For a theological perspective on sexual activity in general, see Appendix 2.)

A follow-up question concerns the timing of their marriage. Are they married at the outset, or is their marriage depicted or assumed at some point in the development of the book? This question is much debated among scholars. My suggestion is that the entire book is devoted to a married couple, since several verses early in the book seem clearly to imply that they are married (e.g., 1:12, 2:9¹²), while others, when compared with similar lines later in the book (e.g., 2:17 // 8:14), point in the same direction. As for those verses in the first couple of chapters that express longing, note that (1) longing is not restricted to the days preceding marriage, for many circumstances and events (not least the many demands of daily life!) preclude constant and full attention on the married relationship, and that (2) some of the future-oriented lines have counterparts *after* the passage (3:7-11) often assumed to be the wedding (e.g., 2:14 // 8:13).

Introduction, Part 6: What to Expect from Song of Songs

In this love poem, we should expect the author to “lift our imagination far above the mundane... [and to] awaken us to the ideas and attitudes that make up the biblical ethic of wedded romantic love” (Ryken and Ryken, 991). In doing so we will be challenged to think rightly about romantic love. When the best sort of marital love has been understood, the stage becomes set for considering the greatest love of all, Christ's death on the cross to redeem a people for himself.

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Translation and Commentary

Translation (1:1)

The author supplies a title for this following work and identifies herself (or himself—see “Notes on Some Details”).

1:1 Song of Songs, which is Shalmah's.

Clarifying the Ideas (1:1)

1:1 Song of Songs: This phraseology most likely does not mean that this is a song made up of multiple independent songs. Rather, in Hebrew idiom the formula “x of xs” means “the best of its class.” Compare, for instance, Deut 10:17, “For the LORD your God is God of gods and Lord of lords, the great, the mighty, and the awesome God, who is not partial and takes no bribe” (ESV): Of all the divinities or authority figures that might be called to mind, the God of the Bible is the best. Applying this idiom to the present verse, it becomes apparent that the author considered the poem (s)he is introducing to be his or her most important. This assessment should generate enthusiasm for what will follow.

Notes on Some Details (1:1)

1:1 which is: Some have thought that the meaning might be “dedicated to” or “inspired by [the literary work of]” (here follows a name, either “Solomon” or “Shalmah”), but there is little evidence that the Hebrew prefix in question would in ancient times have been interpreted in that way in a context like this.

1:1 Shalmah's: Or “Solomon's.” For discussion, see Appendix 1.

Considering the Message (1:1)

The high esteem expected for this song should encourage a deep respect for the institution of marriage (so

¹² Granting the non-literal language of this verse (see “Clarifying the Ideas” there), it is less than certain that the activity depicted is appropriate for an unmarried man (cf., for example, Job 31:1).

also Heb 13:4).

Translation (1:2-4)

The poem begins with the wife's longing for her husband (v2a, 4a-b), intertwining this longing with reflections upon the deep worth of his love towards her (2b, 3a). These reflections are based on a positive evaluation of his reputation (3b-c). The wife, for her part, is applauded for her value by the women who know her (v4c-e).

[Wife:]

1:2a May he kiss me with the kisses of his mouth!

1:2b For your love is better than wine,

1:3a Better than the fragrance of oils.

1:3b Oil when it is being poured out is your name—

1:3c For that reason the young women love you.

1:4a Draw me after you! Let us run!

1:4b Let the king bring me into his bedroom!

[Daughters of Jerusalem, to the wife:]

1:4c We will be glad and rejoice in you;

1:4d We will proclaim your love as better than wine.

1:4e Rightly does he love you.

Clarifying the Ideas (1:1-4)

2a May he kiss me with the kisses of his mouth: In Israelite culture, kissing the lips of someone of the opposite gender was reserved for married individuals, and even more specifically for married individuals expressing their love in private (see “Clarifying the Ideas” on 8:1). What the wife here longs for is a sort of intimacy which the Bible elsewhere makes clear is part of marriage. The four English words **May he kiss me** are all one Hebrew word; thus, the very first word of the song is one of passion.

2b your: Had this poem originally been written in English we probably would have expected “his” for the sake of consistency with the previous line (“he... his”). However, ancient Hebrew poetry regularly shifts abruptly from one vantage point to another, creating a kaleidoscope of perspectives. In this case, the wife initially speaks *about* her husband, but quickly pivots to speak directly *to* him.

3b Oil when it is being poured out: This would suffuse a room with the pleasing aroma of the oil. In ancient Israelite thought, a person's **name** was more than a label: It intersected with identity, character, and legacy. That she would equate his name with the pervasive pleasantness of oil speaks to the admirable way the husband lives his life.

3c For that reason: On account of the husband's moral character (see the previous comment).

3c the young women love you: The Hebrew verb translated “love” here has quite a broad range of meaning. The reference here is not to any romantic entanglements of his with these women (otherwise his **name** would not be **better than the fragrance of oils**), but to his excellent standing in the community.

1:4a Draw me after you! Let us run! The wife wishes for her husband to take her hand and lead the way in a sprint to the bedroom.

1:4b the king: Probably this “is simply a term of affection... [In ancient Egyptian love poetry] lovers are called kings, princes, and queens because of the way love makes them feel about each other and about themselves” (Fox, 98; see further Appendix 4 in the present commentary).

Notes on Some Details (1:1-4)

1:3a I take this as an asseverative *lamedh*; alternatively, see Koehler & Baumgartner 1:509^b sub ָ, usage 19b.

1:3b When it is being: The Hebrew imperfect tense most likely stresses the process, during which the aromas would have been most prominent.

1:3b poured out: Or perhaps “purified,” but given the process of purification the effect would be much the same.

1:3c the young women: This could also be translated “the virgins,” but the use of the same word in 6:8 suggests that that sense is not necessarily applicable here; see further Appendix 3. The definite article is

lacking in Hebrew, but in poetry its use is optional. The bride's understanding of her community is largely limited to women because in that culture men and women from different families generally had little social interaction (cf. Jn 4:27).

1:3c love: This word from a different root (אהב) than the “love” in v2b (אהב); the contrast between the love between the couple and the admiration from the husband's acquaintances is thus clearer in Hebrew than it is in English

1:4b Let the king bring: Taking the Hebrew perfect tense as precative (cf. Dallaire, 141-142) suits the immediate context better, it seems to me, than taking it as an indicative (“the king has brought”). On the meaning of **the king**, see Appendix 4.

1:4b bedroom: This is a contextual translation, as the Hebrew word is a bit vague, but it has reference to a bedroom often enough, and the context so strongly suggests a bedroom (cf. on v2a under “Clarifying the Ideas” above), that it seems best to render it that way here.

1:4e Rightly does he love you: On the textual basis of this translation, see Appendix 5.

Considering the Message (1:1-4)

Love is something the author—and behind the scenes, God the Holy Spirit himself—here celebrates. God has ornamented his creation with many things that are pleasurable to the senses (the examples used in vv2b and 3a are wine and the smell of oil; for basically the same thought, see Ps 104:15), but better than any of these is “the joy of human love.”¹³ So much is this the case that the bride urges her groom on to the place where their love can be celebrated most passionately (v4a-b). If time has seen the romantic spark in a marriage go out, a couple should prayerfully seek ways to reignite that spark.

It does not take away from the excitement of love to see it take place in a context where character is verifiable (3b-c). When one is considering selecting a spouse, careful attention must be paid to spiritual maturity.¹⁴ “*Marriage doesn't change a person's character. If there are character weaknesses in either the husband or the wife, marriage will only reveal and accentuate them*” (Wiersbe, 120). Even in marriage, continual spiritual nourishment for both partners is necessary (Gal 5:15-16). All such evaluations of character ideally take into account the input of the larger community, since puppy love can blind one to the faults of another, and we all need the help of others to escape the snares of sin (1 Cor 10:12, Gal 6:1).

Translation (1:5-8)

The wife expresses a lack of confidence in her appearance (vv6-8) and in her ability to remain close to her husband (v7). He, however, responds with reassurance on both fronts (v8).

[Wife:]

1:5a I am dark[-skinned], but lovely, Daughters of Jerusalem,

1:5b Like the tents of Kedar, like the curtains of Shalmah.

1:6a Do not stare at me on account of my dark complexion,

1:6b On account of how the sun has darkened me,

1:6c [For] my brothers were kindled against me;

1:6d They gave me the job of keeping up the vineyard;

1:6e [As a result] my own vineyard I did not keep up.

1:7a Tell me, you whom my soul loves,

1:7b Where do you shepherd your flock? Where do you settle them down in the afternoon [heat]?

1:7c For why should I be like a prostitute among the flocks of your companions?

[Husband:]

1:8a You do know, most beautiful among women—

1:8b Go out in the tracks of the flock,

1:8c And shepherd your goats in the shepherds' resting places.

¹³ The wording comes from “For the Beauty of the Earth,” a hymn published in 1864 by Folliott S. Pierpoint that celebrates these and other aspects of God's goodness.

¹⁴ By way of clarification, spiritual maturity is not measurable in years since one's conversion to Christ: Paul had great esteem for the Thessalonian believers after a very short time, while the author of Hebrews in 5:12 of his epistle had to reprove some who evidently had been Christians for a considerable period.

Clarifying the Ideas (1:5-8)

1:5a I am dark[-skinned], but lovely: Our own culture also has various unhelpful stereotypes about skin tones.¹⁵ In ancient Israel a light complexion was considered attractive (probably precisely because such a skin tone was difficult to maintain in a sunny climate and in a day when many necessary tasks—from fetching water from the well to tending sheep in the fields—could only be performed outdoors). The wife, however, is well-tanned, her brothers having compelled her to do much hard work out in the family vineyard (v6). She hopes, however, that others will nonetheless recognize some attractiveness (she does not go so far as to say beauty) in her, despite these circumstances.

1:5b tents of Kedar: While we usually think of tents as white or tan, this kind of tent was black, being made from the skins of black goats. **Kedar** was a region known for such tents, as was **Shalmah**.

1:6 The wife poetically shifts the meaning of “vineyard” part way through her statement: First (6d) it refers to a literal plot of cultivated ground requiring laborious maintenance in order to secure goods that the family could use or sell, then (v6e) it refers to her body, which suffers from the beating of the sun and the strain of the work.

1:7-8 These verses are difficult, not so much in the meaning of the individual words, but in the meaning of the question (v7) and of its answer (v8). Surely the verses are not meant to be taken literally, for if she genuinely did not know where in the fields to find him, his answer is unhelpful (if she was skillful enough to follow the tracks his flock left behind, she would not have asked the question; if she were not skilled in this area, his instructions would do her no good); moreover, Song of Songs is so full of metaphors and similes that the book all but begs the reader to look for a meaning that lies deeper than the mere terminology used. The preceding context, relating to her insecurity, seems to offer a clue. Another clue comes from the poem’s “quest motif” (Ryken and Ryken, 989)—that is, from the constant appeals throughout the book for physical and emotional closeness. What she seeks here is reassurance over their enduring bond. The husband’s response: “You will find a way.” That is to say, the wife holds within her the ability to attain her goal (in the figurative language of the poem, this goal is to shepherd her flock; in the real intent of the discourse, it is to continue truly to be his life partner). In pointing her to what she already knows, he subverts her negative self-perception, and expresses his confidence that her attachment to him is anything but temporary.

Notes on Some Details (1:5-8)

1:5b Shalmah: The Hebrew letters here are typically vocalized in a way that produces the name “Solomon,” but it is not known whether he was somehow associated with dark curtains. “Shalmah,” however, makes good sense as a locale where one would expect such material.

1:6b darkened me: Another possible meaning is “gazed upon me.”

1:6c my brothers: Literally “the sons of my mother,” but the wording is probably not meant to be pejorative or to imply that they are sons of a different father than her own. (The wording might be due to the needs of the meter and/or reflect good Hebrew style.)

1:6c were kindled against me: This seems to be the literal sense of the Hebrew, and though this translation sounds strange in English, it has the advantage that it highlights what might be a wordplay, implicitly comparing the effects of the sun (v6b) upon her to the effects of her brothers upon her. The English translations I checked have “were angry with me,” which is possibly correct, but perhaps the meaning is something like, “were overbearing with me” or, “were harsh with me.”

1:7c a prostitute: Literally, “one who veils herself.” At least at certain times and places and at least in some circumstances, prostitutes in ancient Israel wore a veil which hid their faces (cf. Gen 38:15).¹⁶

¹⁵ In ancient Israel “[s]uch scorn would originate in social, not racial, prejudices” (Fox, 101).

¹⁶ That some men were willing to have sex with a woman whose face they could not see highlights the preoccupation those men had with their own pleasure, for certainly a man who does not know a woman’s identity or see her face has not developed an interest in her as a human being with a soul, a personality, and a unique life story. (This observation is not meant to imply that a close friendship justifies sexual interaction: Every marriage should also be a friendship, but not every friendship is a marriage.) The husband depicted in Song of Songs stands in marked contrast to those who would visit a prostitute: His interest is in her whole person, not just a few select parts of his body; he does not insist on his way (5:2-6); he reassures her when she is insecure (as the present passage and the following show); and he appreciates her moral character, not her beauty only (8:10).

It is also instructive to note that in such cases of prostitution it was the women who felt a need to hide their

Perhaps something about the structure of the poetry prompted the circumlocution, or perhaps so direct a term as “prostitute” felt out of place here, but in English a literal translation would in my opinion be hopelessly opaque.

Considering the Message (1:5-8)

As in ancient Israel, so in our day there are many unrealistic and misplaced expectations concerning physical appearance. Women of color in particular might be made to feel negatively self-conscious about their own skin tone, or other aspects of their appearance. Part of the role of the community (cf. 1:11, 6:13), and of one's husband in the case of a married woman (1:8a), is to affirm the God-given beauty of each woman. Affirmation and acceptance should be characteristic of Christian community (Rom 15:7). Even if fellow Christians fail in this regard, women can know that God in heaven both made them and called them “very good” (Gen 1:31); whatever the eyes of fallen humanity see, the eyes of God who is great in truth (Ex 34:6) see someone of eternal worth. Neither body type, nor skin tone, nor scars, nor anything else should deter one from recognizing one's worth as God's creation. Even disabilities are no cause to look down on one's self, as God takes full responsibility for these difficulties and intends to work in spite of (sometimes, even through) them (Ex 4:11, Isa 45:7, 2 Cor 12:10).

Along similar lines, anxieties over one's own ability to maintain proper beliefs and behavior long-term can be unsettling (v7). But as demonstrated by the husband's confidence (v8), part of love is a decision to think the best of someone (1 Cor 13:7). Sometimes a correct assessment is to be found not on the lips of the individual concerned, but rather on the lips of those around him or her (so it is in 1 Jn 5:13 that John can evidently be more sure of his readers' salvation than they themselves are).

Translation (1:9-14)

The groom affirms the beauty of his wife (vv9-10). Though his mention of jewelry in v10 is incidental, the Daughters of Jerusalem see in this element of his words of praise an opportunity tangibly to express their own commitment to supporting the wife (v11). The wife then reflects to herself on how events proved that her husband's sentiments were not mere words (v12), and reiterates her own enduring affection for him (vv13-14).

[Husband:]

1:9a To a mare among the chariot [horses] of Pharaoh,

1:9b I compare you, my friend.

1:10a Lovely are your cheeks with *torim*,

1:10b Your neck with a *kharuz* necklace.

[Daughters of Jerusalem, to the wife:]

1:11a Golden *torim* we will make for you,

1:11b With silver beads.

[Wife:]

1:12a While the king was [reclining] on his *mesabh*,

1:12b He became entranced with [the fragrance of] my nard.

1:13a A sachet of myrrh is my beloved to me,

1:13b Spending the night between my breasts.

1:14a A cluster of henna flowers is my beloved to me,

1:14b In the vineyards of Engedi.

Clarifying the Ideas (1:9-14)

1:9a Even when Song of Songs was composed Egypt's pyramids were ancient, and its equestrian prowess was legendary. The nobility, strength, and grace of the best horses of Egypt sprang to the husband's mind as he considered his wife. She was, in his eyes, no ordinary farm girl!

identity, not the men. A sexual double-standard existed then which made things precarious for women who engaged in extramarital sex but largely ignored the sexual sins of men (cf. Gen 38:21, v24). Moreover, the danger for women just alluded to suggests that economic crisis must at times have been the catalyst for women turning to this type of work. Our own time and place are not immune to these problems, and these problems must be faced with justice and with compassion.

1:9b my friend: This term highlights an important aspect of a healthy marriage relationship—friendship. Friends spend time together, cry together, play together, and talk together.

1:10a torim: The meaning of the word is not completely clear, but it is certainly a kind of jewelry, probably large hoops that hang along the jawline.

1:10b a kharuz necklace: The meaning is unclear; the reference appears to be some kind of necklace with small parts (sea shells?; so Koehler & Baumgartner, 1:351^b) somehow interlocked. At any rate, the larger point in vv9-10 is that his bride, contrary to what she might have feared (vv5-6), is indeed beautiful. The jewelry that she wore (which he does not mention immediately: Notice its absence from v9), moreover, is a fitting complement to her natural attractiveness.

1:11 Seizing on the husband's mention (v10b) of jewelry, the Daughters of Jerusalem see an opportunity to play their part in supporting their friend the wife by seeing to it that she has no shortage of accessories.

1:12a mesabh: I resort to a transliteration here because there seemingly is no modern (Western) equivalent to this piece of ancient Israelite furniture. It was something like a small couch at which one would recline on one's side at mealtimes. The cushioned seating and the relaxed postures would, circumstances permitting, lend themselves to encounters of a certain kind between a married couple.

1:12b nard: An aromatic plant from South Asia.

1:12a-b: The essential idea behind these lines seems to be that the wife recognizes with satisfaction and with pleasure (cf. 13a-14b) that, her previously expressed sense of insecurity (5-6) aside, her husband did indeed find her attractive.

1:13a myrrh: Myrrh was used as a perfume, in this case in a **sachet** probably tied to a long circle of string hung around the neck.

1:13b spending the night between my breasts: In ancient Israel the word “breast” was not taboo, and was not necessarily an erotic term (see, for example, Lk 11:27). Moreover, the surrounding lines are not explicit or inappropriate for public reading. That said, the wife does with these words express a desire for a profoundly intimate relationship with her husband.

1:14a a cluster of henna flowers: These flowers produce a dye with which women could create body art via temporary tattoos. The idea might be that as the henna plant allowed her to express herself artistically, so her husband brought out the best in her personality.

1:14b Engedi: Engedi is a ruggedly beautiful place, a bit similar to the Grand Canyon. This can hardly have been their literal location (trying to take all the locales mentioned in Song of Songs literally would hardly be possible), but evoking Engedi transfers the mesmerizing atmosphere of that locale to their lives together.

Notes on Some Details (1:9-14)

1:9a a mare: Or “my mare,” but it seems best to take this as a construct form (cf. Cowley, 253 §90/(a)).

1:11b beads: Or “drops” (cf. Koehler & Baumgartner 1:720^a).

1:12b My translation is adapted from the NLT.

Considering the Message (1:9-14)

This passage, like so many in Song of Songs, implies that high praise for one's partner ought to characterize marriage. Verses 10-11, incidentally, imply that jewelry (and by implication, things like hair styling) has its place and can be an appropriate complement to natural beauty. What the New Testament (1 Pet 3:3-6) forbids is building through such means as jewelry a public image as an impressive person—attempting, in other words, to purchase the applause of peers through external extravagance.

In 1:12-13 we seemingly have an allusion to a sexual experience between the husband and the wife of this poem, or at least a reference to a level of intimacy that some readers of holy Scripture might be shocked to see mentioned there. But God's discernment can be trusted. In fact, sexual activity between a man and a woman married to each other is not only necessary and permissible, but good and right (see Appendix 2). As already noted (cf. “Clarifying the Ideas” on 13b), the language is not so pictorial as in itself to prompt voyeurism. Here and throughout Song of Songs sexuality is discussed gently; the author's aim is not to shock sensibilities, or even to educate readers on matters of anatomy and physiology. If in past eras there was a tendency on the part of some to spiritualize this book in an exegetically ill-founded way, I would

suggest that in recent years the pendulum has at times swung too far in the other direction. This passage of Scripture does not tarnish the reputation of the institution of marriage by associating that institution with feelings of embarrassment—as would be the case if the passage used tawdry or puerile language—for sex, a creation of God, is neither something to be ashamed of nor something to be snickered at. On the contrary, the Bible here takes care to elevate the human relationship in question by invoking a panorama of nature's noblest aspects, from the artistic potential of henna to the sweeping grandeur of Engedi. What God created, he created good (Gen 1:31).

Translation (1:15-2:7)

Husband and wife play off one another's kind words to each other (1:15-2:3), after which the wife basks in her security in (2:4) and love for (v5-6) her husband. In view of the value of such true love, she urges her female friends not to rush matters with respect to their own potential romantic relationships (v7).

[Husband:]

1:15a Oh, how beautiful you are, my friend!

1:15b Oh, how beautiful you are! Your eyes are doves.

[Wife:]

1:16a Oh, how handsome you are, my beloved!

1:16b You are so charming! And our bed is verdant!

1:17a The beams of our house are cedars;

1:17b Our rafters are junipers.

2:1a I am an asphodel of the Sharon,

2:1b A water lotus of the valleys.

[Husband:]

2:2a Like a water lotus among the thorn bushes,

2:2b So is my friend among women.

[Wife:]

2:3a Like an apple tree among the trees of the forest,

2:3b So is my beloved among men;

2:3c In its shade I delightedly sat down,

2:3d And its fruit was sweet to my taste.

2:4a He brought me in to the house of wine,

2:4b And his banner over me was love.

2:5a Sustain me with raisin cakes;

2:5b Renew my strength with apples!

2:5c For I am lovesick.

2:6a Let his left hand be under my head,

2:6b And his right hand embrace me!

2:7a I adjure you, Daughters of Jerusalem,

2:7b By the gazelles, or by does of the field,

2:7c Not to stir up or awaken love

2:7d Until it pleases.

Clarifying the Ideas (1:15-2:7)

1:15b your eyes are doves: Some doves in ancient Israel were dark in color, so the reference is probably to the iris.

1:16a handsome: This is the same Hebrew word twice translated “beautiful” in v15, except for the final vowel, which differs in accordance with the difference in gender. Thus it is clearer in Hebrew than it is in English that she is playing off his praise of her, echoing, with appropriate modifications, his own words as she praises him.

1:16b is verdant: The wife is using the imagery of thriving plant life or fruit to describe the place where the two of them lie together (and to imply a flourishing sex life).

1:17a cedars: A highly prized wood from Lebanon.

1:17b junipers: These are “trees that produce a pleasant scent, making this spot a pleasant place for

an intimate encounter” (Longman, 108).

1:17a-b: She probably does not intend these lines to be taken literally, for it does not seem likely that this couple could afford such a house; furthermore, the poet elsewhere takes a dim view of displays of wealth (cf. especially 8:7c-d, 8:11a-v12c). Rather, just as 1:16b does not (ultimately) describe the bed itself, but rather their life together associated with it, so here she might be using the imagery of exquisite architecture to elaborate on the great value of their relationship.

2:1a In identifying with a beautiful and delicate plant, the wife shows that her self-image has improved from the previous chapter. On the other hand, she does not pick an extravagant image for herself. **the Sharon** is a coastal plain in central Israel, a place of quiet beauty.

2:2a among the thorn bushes: A reference to other females to whom his wife might in theory be compared; when it comes to his affection, they might as well be **thorn bushes**, while his wife is a beautiful **water lotus**. In this way the husband adapts his wife's language from v1b.

2:3a among the trees of the forest: That is, among other males to whom her husband might be compared. The wife here adapts the language her husband used in 2:2a.

2:3c-d Just as an apple tree provides **shade** from the heat of the day and **sweet fruit** to replenish the body's energy, so her husband offers protection (for more on this idea, cf. “Considering the Message” to 8:5-10) and enjoyable company (cf. “Clarifying the Ideas” to 1:9b).

2:4a house of wine: The reference is unclear; perhaps some kind of tavern is meant (cf. Ecc 7:2, where the phrase sometimes translated “house of feasting” is more literally rendered “house of drinking”).

2:5a Sustain me with raisin cakes: Possibly playing off her own recent (and metaphorical) mention of feasting (cf. 2:4a), the wife uses the imagery of a sugar low—a remedy for which would be **raisin cakes** to verbalize the overwhelming sensation of recognizing her husband's deep love for her (so she says in v6c). (This particular sort of sweet item probably had romantic connotations in that culture, a bit like chocolates today.)

2:6 In other words, “I look forward to his embrace!”

2:7a I adjure you, Daughters of Jerusalem: The wife has something to say (which will appear in 7c-d) to her friends that is so important that she casts it in courtroom language.

2:7b By the gazelles, or by the does of the field: Fittingly for a remark about love in a love poem, she bases her appeal on beautiful and graceful creatures.

Notes on Some Details (1:15-2:7)

1:15a Oh: The Hebrew word הנה is used to focus or to redirect attention. Traditionally, the word is translated into English as “behold”; in the present translation, a variety of context-informed translation techniques are employed.

1:17b rafters: The *kethib* רהיטנו is apparently a *lapsus calami* for רהיטנו.

2:2b women: Literally, “daughters,” but this English word would sound odd or misleading in this context (the Hebrew בת often refers to female members of a class, here female members of humanity).

2:3b men: Literally “sons.”

2:3c, d its: Both occurrences of “its” could be translated also “his”; the question is whether the pronouns refer directly to the husband (“his”) or indirectly, by referring to the tree of the metaphor (“its”).

2:4a the house of wine: The Hebrew word for “house” (בית) boasts a wide variety of figurative uses, so there is not necessarily an implication that people live, or even sleep, in this location.

2:7a I adjure you: “Oaths... are by no means consistently forbidden in Scripture. God himself takes oaths to guarantee the fulfillment of what he has promised... [What James says in 5:12 is that] our truthfulness should be so consistent and dependable that we need no oath to support it” (Moo, 232-233). SS 2:7b, in other words, does not contradict the spirit of Jm 5:12 or similar verses.

2:7b By the gazelles, or by the does of the field: It is widely thought that the Hebrew here (בצבאות או) is a deliberately scrambled version of something like, “By the Lord of hosts, or by God Almighty” (באלוהים או באל שדי). I am not quite certain that this is the case, since the words actually used fit the tenor of the poem so well, but quite possibly seeing bucolic imagery and seeing an indirect reference to God here are not mutually exclusive.

Considering the Message (1:15-2:7)

The husband and wife here model mutuality with their mouths: One partner does not soak up the approval of the other, simply nodding in agreement; rather, the praise of one prompts the other to launch into a serenade for their spouse. The husband is certainly aware of females beside his wife (1:2a-b), and the wife is certainly aware of males besides her husband (1:3a-b), but each reassures the other of their unique place in their affections. The husband is particularly noted for his enjoyable presence (2:3c-d) and generous (2:4a-b) and affecting (2:5a-c) love. It is in this context that the marriage bed is blessed (1:16b-17b, 2:5a-6b).

If a single believer desires a marriage bed, it is an honorable thing he or she desires (Heb 13:4). Yet because it is an honorable thing, 2:7 counsels such individuals “not to force it... Wait for love to blossom; don't try to stimulate it artificially” (Longman, 115). Marriage is not to be pursued at any cost, for while there is great potential for a God-honoring life in the married state, there is also potential for disaster, a disaster which could extend beyond the couple to others, especially any children they have. Patience is necessary, and patient obedience will be honored by God, whose plans for his people, though at times difficult to understand in the moment, are good.

Translation (2:8-14)

The husband approaches his wife (2:8-9) and, beginning to speak (10a), uses the imagery of springtime (11a-13b) and of a bird in a secluded place (14a-b) for his desire for her loving attention (10b-c, 13c, 14c-f). This, his first lengthy monologue, is in fact a speech within a speech, for the entire section is cast as the wife's imaginative recollection.

[Wife:]

2:8a [I hear] the sound of my beloved!

2:8b Look, he is coming,

2:8c Skipping on the mountains,

2:8d [And] leaping on the hills.

2:9a My beloved is like a gazelle,

2:9b Or the young [and strong] offspring of the deer,

2:9c Look, [now] he is standing at the house,

2:9d Peering through the windows,

2:9e Gazing through the lattice.

2:10a My beloved said to me,

2:10b “Rise up, my friend,

2:10c “My beautiful one, and come along!

2:11a “For look—the winter is past,

2:11b “And the rain[y season] has gone on its way.

2:12a “The blossoms are appearing in the land,

2:12b “The time of pruning has drawn near,

2:12c “And the voice of the turtle-dove is heard in our land.

2:13a “The fig tree is forming young fruit,

2:13b “And the young fruit has given forth its fragrance.

2:13c “Oh, arise, my friend, my beautiful one, and come!

2:14a “A dove in the clefts of the rock,

2:14b “In the hiding place of the steep slope,

2:14c “Show me your appearance,

2:14d “[And] let me hear your voice,

2:14e “For your voice is sweet,

2:14f “And your form is lovely.”

Clarifying the Ideas (2:8-14)

2:8c-d skipping... leaping: As 9a-b makes clear, the wife describes her husband in terms of a gazelle.

2:9c-e: Just as vv8c-d are metaphorical (see the preceding comment), so too are these lines: He is not literally peering into her house or her room, or simply (vv11-13) pointing out the beauty of springtime, but inviting her to the refreshing and life-giving adventure of romance.

2:11b “Since the rains [in Israel] end in April, it is likely that the scene evokes a temporal setting in

May” (Longman, 121).

2:14a a dove in the clefts of the rock: Many birds find homes in locations (deep in a bush, or in this case, in the cavities of a rocky slope) that are both secure and hidden from the eyes of others. Similarly, the husband wishes to be alone with his wife, there to see and hear her in ways that no one else may.

Notes on Some Details (2:8-14)

2:8a sound: The Hebrew (קול) could also be translated “voice.” This fact suggests that 2:14e, 5:2b, and 8:13c echo (in various ways) the present line.

2:9b [and strong]: Cf. on “fawns” in 4:5a under “Clarifying the Ideas (4:1-5:1).”

2:9c house: Literally, “wall,” but in this context the wall of a house is meant.

2:9d through: More literally, “from,” but this is a minor linguistic difference in perspective, Hebrew indicating here the place from which the activity (of peering) takes place, rather than the direction of the activity. (The same comment applies in the following line.)

2:9d-e: It is not clear to me whether what he is depicted as peering into is her house or her room, but it probably makes little difference here which it is.

2:10a said: Literally, “answered me,” but this Hebrew idiom does not imply a previous question.

2:13a: This rendering is slightly adapted from the NLT.

2:13c I attempt to replicate the energy suggested by the two-fold לך.

2:14a: A dove: Or “my dove,” but I take this as a construct form, like לססתי in 1:9a.

Considering the Message (2:8-14)

As noted in the summary, even though most of the words in this section are the husband's, these words are embedded in the wife's words of glad recollection. In fact, large sections of Song of Songs reflect her words, thoughts, and reactions. She is not an add-on, but a human being with her own voice. Her use of her own distinctive voice does not deter her husband, who is a man of good character (1:2-3). Indeed, throughout Song of Songs he proves to be intensely interested in every aspect of her. Accordingly, a woman should not fear that expressing herself will push away anyone who ought to be in her life. A relationship (romantic or otherwise) is likely a toxic one if one person is constantly made to feel ashamed or unworthy; is cut off from communication with people outside of that relationship; or is monitored in an obsessive way. This situation is detrimental to one's emotional and mental health. It might even become physically dangerous. In the event that one suspects that one is part of a toxic relationship, one should consult with a biblical counselor if possible, and flee to a safe place if necessary.¹⁷

The husband seeks to capture his wife's imagination (2:10a-13b, 14a-b) and to appeal to her own volition (10b-c, 13c-d, 14c-d). Elsewhere in Scripture we learn that even God, though sovereign over all his creation (Rom 9:21), nevertheless channels his grace to his elect in such a way that they hear not the barking call of a slave-driver but the soothing summons of the caretaker (Jn 10:4, Gal 4:5-6). Of course, husbands have no such power over their wives, who after all are “coheirs of the grace of life” (1 Pet 3:7 CSB). Yet husbands ought to look to evoke willing participation.

While married believers should not shut themselves out from fellowship with the rest of the Church or from extending a helping hand to the world around them, 14a-b suggests that there are aspects of marriage which are exclusive. It is vital to carve out time to give specific, undistracted time to one's spouse.

It was observed above that the husband delights himself in many aspects of his wife; he does not limit his attention to a few purely sexual elements.¹⁸ v14d is an example of this wide-ranging delight, the very timbre of her voice catching his attention. He not only sees her with his eyes, he hears her with his ears. A wise man does not sell himself short by settling for a superficial knowledge of his wife, but seeks to learn her well (1 Pet 3:7).

¹⁷ One might wonder how this advice reconciles with the biblical directive for wives to submit to their husbands (see for example 1 Pet 3:1-6). I would offer an analogous case: Jesus called for submission to civic authority, even imperialistic civic authority (Mat 22:21), yet told preachers of the gospel to flee persecution (Mat 10:23). Submission to God-ordained authority figures is the ideal, but it is always understood that some circumstances can render this impossible; in such cases, submission is not required.

¹⁸ A similar thought occurs in Fox (299-300). Even in sex itself, “a man needs to learn how to be romantic, tender, and nurturing... When a man sees sex as being devoid of the love connection, reducing it to mere biological release, that man robs himself of true ecstasy” (Hart, 198). Violence and romance, including sexual romance, are incompatible.

Translation (2:15-17)

The wife calls on her friends to assist her and her husband in maintaining their relationship (2:15). This call for assistance does not mean that she is insecure in her relationship (v16); indeed, she is eager to continue passionate romance with her husband (v17).

[Wife:]

2:15a Catch the foxes for us,

2:15b The little foxes that spoil the vineyards,

2:15c For our vineyard is blossoming.

2:16a My beloved is mine,

2:16b And I am his—

2:16c He who shepherds among the asphodels.

2:17a Until the wind dissipates,

2:17b And the shadows flee,

2:17c Oh, come, my beloved, and be like a gazelle,

2:17d Or like the young [and strong] offspring of the deer

2:17e On the rugged mountains.

Clarifying the Ideas (2:15-17)

2:15a foxes: These famously crafty animals can cause endless headaches for farmers. They are thus an apt metaphor for unforeseen points of friction that threaten to undermine the vitality of the relationship. The wife appeals to her friends (presumably the “Daughters of Jerusalem”) to assist in rooting out these problems.

2:16c He who shepherds among the asphodels: The wife pictures her husband as a shepherd. Shepherds protect and care for those under their charge (cf. Ps 23:1-2, Jn 10:2-4). By picturing his shepherding work as **among the asphodels**, she uses bucolic imagery to highlight the quiet wholesomeness of his work.

2:17a Until the wind dissipates: Either a reference to regular evening breezes in Israel, or to a storm from which the couple takes refuge in the safety of their bedroom. In the latter case, the storm is probably not literal, or even necessarily indicative of some problem in their environment, but either a foil for the peace of their relationship or an enchanting backdrop for their enchanted relationship.

2:17b And the shadows flee: In other words (so it seems; the Hebrew of 17a-b is difficult to understand), “And [until] morning comes,” “All night long.” Deer (see lines c-d) are largely nocturnal, a fact which, at least in part, likely motivated this choice of language. Of course, this imagery can also allude subtly to certain other nocturnal activities.

2:17c-e be like a gazelle... On the rugged mountains: As in 2:8-9, the wife invokes the gazelle, an animal which boasts astonishing speed and agility on even the steepest and rockiest of slopes. She wishes for him wholeheartedly to find fulfillment in her arms.

Notes on Some Details (2:15-17)

2:17a Until the wind dissipates: This is a difficult line. Among the other possible translations for the word (יִם) here rendered “wind” are “day[light]” and “storm”; other possible translations of the word (פֶּחַח) here rendered “dissipates” (I have tried to pick up on some of the nuances of defeat that the word seems at times to bear; cf. Jastrow, 1140^a) include “breathe” and “blow.” (Presumably the original audience knew what this line meant, especially since it gets reused in 4:6!)

2:17c come: More literally, “turn,” but the Hebrew verb in question (סָבַב) is at times more of a preparatory particle (cf. Brown, Driver, & Briggs, 685^a). **my beloved, and:** For the sake of English style I have moved the position of the words **my beloved** (in Hebrew they stand after **be**) and added a conjunction.

2:17e rugged mountains: The meaning of the Hebrew is unclear. This rendering is borrowed from the NLT. Another possibility is “mountains of spices,” in which case the idea is the exotic nature of the destination.

Considering the Message (2:15-17)

The **foxes** are **little** (2:15b). When marriages fail (whether formally, through divorce; or informally, through

a marriage without love), it is rarely due to sudden catastrophe. What typically separates spouses is a slow accumulation of ordinary, but unresolved, problems. Couples should be on the alert for small problems, even when things seem to be going well (15c), and with the Spirit's help mend them before they become giant.

The wife here makes an appeal to friends outside the marriage for help with her marriage. This is not an excuse for gossiping about one's spouse. But realism calls for assistance; no couple should assume that between the two of them they hold all the answers to life's mysteries. The Church provides just such a resource (Rom 15:14), and married couples should cultivate friendships within their local congregation.

In v16 the wife utters the first of three (see also 6:3 and 7:10) statements of mutual ownership. Ownership, rightly understood, entails a deep commitment. It is probably this entailed commitment that explains the transition from troubleshooting in v15 to romance in v17. A firm resolution to continue the marriage will create a willingness to work through the problems that inevitably will arise, and a shared confidence that the bond is not transactional or fleeting, will create a context in which genuine affection can grow.

And grow it does: The wife in v17 uses the evocative imagery of a gazelle prancing on rugged mountains to call for daring romance all night long. "God isn't a spoilsport who wants to keep people from having sex. He's a loving, masterful Creator who wants husbands and wives to experience passionate, physical intimacy for a lifetime. God went to a lot of trouble to create the sexual parts of a man and woman, and much of what He placed in us is not necessary to make a baby. It's simply His gift" (Jaynes).

Translation (3:1-5)

The wife has a dream in which she searches for (3:1-3) and eventually finds (3:4a-b) her beloved, whom she brings to her childhood home (3:4c-e). As a coda to the section she again calls on the Daughters of Jerusalem to attach sufficient value to true love to wait for it (3:5)

[Wife:]

3:1a On my bed at night I searched

3:1b For the one my soul loves.

3:1c I searched for him but did not find him.

3:2a [I thought,] "I will arise and go around

3:2b "The city, the squares, and the plazas;

3:2c "I will seek the one my soul loves."

3:2d I searched for him but did not find him.

3:3a The sentries who go around the city found me.

3:3b [I asked them,] "Have you seen the one my soul loves?"

3:4a I had barely moved on from them

3:4b When I found the one my soul loves.

3:4c I held him and did not let go

3:4d Until I had brought him to the house of my mother,

3:4e And to the room of the one who conceived me.

3:5a I adjure you, Daughters of Jerusalem,

3:5b By the gazelles, or by does of the field,

3:5c Not to stir up or awaken love

3:5d Until it pleases.

Clarifying the Ideas (3:1-5)

3:1-4 The description here cannot be literal. The terms **bed** and **night** in 3:1, combined with the similarities to 5:2-7, indicate that this segment is a description of a dream that she has had. In her dream, she awakes to discover that her husband is not in bed next to her. She sets out on a quest to search the city for him and eventually finds him. Her dream concludes with her showing him the place where she was born.

3:4d-e: Respect for parents ran far higher in ancient Israelite culture than it does in mainstream American culture. Childbirth, meanwhile, was not a taboo subject. In these line of poetry, then, she expresses her insistent desire that her husband become familiar with the details of her childhood (a time of life modern psychological analysis certainly considers formative) and her life story.

3:5 For discussion, see on 2:7 under "Clarifying the Ideas."

Notes on Some Details (3:1-5)

3:2a: The Hebrew particle וְ lends an energy to the utterance not easily rendered in written English (a well-crafted spoken word performance might succeed better).

3:5 On the question of oath-taking, see “Notes on Some Details” to 2:7b.

Considering the Message (3:1-5)

Often dreams reflect, if in strange and unpredictable ways, the preoccupations of our minds or the yearnings of our heart. The wife has so made her husband a part of her life that he, her passion for him, and her desire for him to have a thorough understanding of her, have worked their way even into her dreams. While it might be tempting for some not to invest themselves to this extent in their spouse, the marriage bond in any case requires deep investment. Christ did not hold back in his investment in us (Phil 2:4-8).

Translation (3:6-11)

Attention is first drawn to the wife by means of a riddle (v6), then turns to an impressive procession (vv7-11).

[Daughters of Jerusalem, concerning the wife:]

3:6a Who is this coming from the desert,

3:6b Like a column of dust, scented with myrrh and frankincense,

3:6c [Scented] better than any aromatic a merchant could offer?

[Wife:]

3:7a Take a look—it's the litter of Solomon!

3:7b Sixty warriors surround it

3:7c From the warriors of Israel.

3:8a All of them are grasping a sword, trained in war,

3:8b Each man with his sword on his thigh, [guarding] against the terror of the night.

3:9a Solomon the king has made a litter for himself

3:9b From the wood of Lebanon.

3:10a Its pillars he made with silver;

3:10b Its supports with gold.

3:10c His chariot is purple;

3:10d Its interior covered with leather

3:10e From the Daughters of Jerusalem.

3:11a Go out and look, daughters of Zion, on King Solomon,

3:11b With the crown with which his mother crowned him

3:11c On the day of his marriage, and his day of gladness of heart.

Clarifying the Ideas (3:6-11)

3:6a: The attention-grabbing “Who is this?” appears here for the first of three times (it also occurs in 6:10 and 8:5). It becomes evident (by 6:10, if not sooner) that the answer to the riddle is the wife, but by posing things as a riddle the Daughters of Jerusalem draw in the listeners, and by using mysterious and awe-inspiring language they signal that this woman, despite her own previous misgivings about her appearance (1:5-6), is in fact a person of profound significance.

3:6 column of dust: Such as it would be stirred up in a sandy place by the wind. The phenomenon surely bespeaks both power and mystery, the forces involved being unseen and unpredictable. **scented with myrrh and frankincense:** Either a mixing of metaphors (something Hebrew poetry never shrinks from), or an indication that the **desert** depicted in this verse is the Arabian peninsula, from which source myrrh and frankincense would in ancient times have (directly or indirectly, via trade routes to such places as Somalia) have come. Either way, these exotic scents add to the sense of mystique with which the Daughters of Jerusalem surround the wife.

3:7a litter: That is, a chair raised up and carried by strong men.

3:8b [guarding] against the terror of the night: Probably these words do not imply any known, pressing danger, but instead highlight the honor in which the man on the litter is held. An analogy would be the manner in which even in peaceful times the President of the United States is everywhere accompanied by

armed guards.

3:11a go out and look: I suspect the tone is ironic: King Solomon puts on quite a show, to be sure, but beyond the spectacle there is little that will last.

Notes on Some Details (3:6-11)

3:7-11 It is difficult to assess the meaning and tone of this segment. There are three basic interpretive approaches: (1) Perhaps the reference is to King Solomon, who is the groom/husband in Song of Songs. In this case the tone is positive. (2) Perhaps the reference is to the husband, who is not literally identical to King Solomon, but is referred to that way by his wife playfully (see Appendix 4). In this case the tone is positive. (3) Perhaps the reference is to King Solomon, whose ostentation and hypocrisy is held up for examination in order to present a contrast with the purer love of the husband. In this case the tone is negative, or at least ironic. The first option is hard to accept in light of King Solomon's marital failures, failures alluded to in this very book (6:8; see further under "The Characters in the Book" in the Introduction). The second option is appealing in the light of references to the husband as "the king" elsewhere in the book (1:4, 12, 7:6), but in those places the name "Solomon" is avoided, and, outside of the book's title (1:1), the name is only used in 8:11-12, where Solomon is viewed negatively, or at least as a point of contrast. The third option seems best.¹⁹ That said, this conclusion is held loosely, since there is so much here that is uncertain.

3:6a Who: Some commentators translate "what," understanding the answer to be the litter of Solomon (7a), but while there are instances of the Hebrew מִי having an impersonal referent, such usage is rare. Moreover, this line seems to be one of the poet's triads (cf. Part 3 of the Introduction), and in its other occurrences (6:10, 8:5) the reference is clearly to the wife, so it most likely refers to her here as well.

3:6b a column of dust: The meaning of the Hebrew is not entirely clear, but the wording is quite dramatic, as indicated by the presence of the same words in Joel 2:30 (in Hebrew, 3:3).

3:6c: Another possible rendering is "[Scented] with every aromatic a merchant has to offer." Probably these two ways of understanding the Hebrew amount to the same thing, for while the one rendering elevates the quality of the items mentioned in 6b, and the other rendering expands the scope of 6b, in either case the rarity, and hence value, of the bride's qualities (for the terms are not, I think, ultimately to be taken literally) is celebrated. On the other hand, if the rendering "[scented better than any aromatic a merchant could offer," given in the translation above, is (substantially) correct, there might be an implicit criticism of King Solomon, whose impressive display will follow in vv7-11: The wife has something that money (with which merchants are associated) cannot buy (as Solomon might think, with all his pompous display), namely, love to offer freely to her spouse (cf. 8:7c-d, 11-12).

3:7-11 I have ascribed these words to the wife, but they could be the husband's.²⁰

3:7a litter: This is a contextual rendering of what in Hebrew (מטה) is a less specific term (roughly, "bed"). The word rendered "litter" in 9a is different (אפריון).

3:7b sixty: The number might have been chosen partly as an excessive number of bodyguards for a peacetime (1 Chron 22:9) monarch and partly for its alliteration (ששים) with Solomon (שלמה). It is also possible that it was meant to take on an ominous tone when the poem was read a second time, for later in the poem (6:8) the same number reappears in a way that brings attention to a dark side of Solomon's reign.

3:10d leather: An alternative rendering is "love," a rendering which might be preferable if the tone here is positive instead of negative (cf. the comments on 3:7-11 above). I suspect that the ambiguity between the meanings "love" and "leather" here is deliberate, allowing for an irony in which the monarch Solomon thinks his subjects obsessed with him, whereas in fact they are wearied by his demands for the production of such materials (cf. 1 Sam 8:11-18, 1 Ki 12:4).

3:11c the day of his marriage: If the tone in this passage is negative, a subtle irony is presented, for while the male protagonist of the poem demonstrates a clear fidelity to his wife (6:9a), King Solomon is busy entering into his sixty-first (6:8a) marriage!

¹⁹ Fox objects that on this model "the passage would be describing at length what is scorned" (123), but the length of a literary unit is not always indicative of a desire for the actions or ideas described in that unit to be emulated (e.g., the author of Ecclesiastes devotes much space to approaches to life which he will ultimately deem futile).

²⁰ Recall that the headings attributing any given section to a speaker are not in the original Hebrew; they have been provided here (in brackets) for clarity, but could on occasion be mistaken.

Considering the Message (3:6-11)

In 3:6 we are reminded to think of the wife in terms far more magnificent than what might first spring to our minds. She is not just “some woman,” but a human being fashioned by a loving and powerful creator. Every woman and man—no matter her or his age, country of origin, skin color, linguistic distinctives, or socio-economic status—is a being of far greater significance than we can grasp. “There are no *ordinary* people. You have never talked to a mere mortal” (Lewis, 46).

The message of vv7-11 is difficult to assess (see “Notes on Some Details” above). If the tone is positive, the extravagant imagery highlights the value of the marriage. “Since they are no longer two but one, let no one split apart what God has joined together” Mat 19:6, NLT). If the tone is negative (as I think is the case), the imagery invites a comparison between what money can buy and what love can cultivate. “A bowl of vegetables with someone you love is better than steak with someone you hate” (Pr 15:17, NLT).

Translation (4:1-5:1)

The husband offers effusive words of praise for his wife's attractiveness and her hold over him (4:1a-4:5c, 4:7a—b, 4:9a-15c), intertwining these words of praise with fervent wishes for further expressions of love (4:6a-d, 4:8a-f). She verbalizes her wish that he enjoy a fulfilling time with her (4:16a-f), to which he responds with affirmation (5:1a-d). The Daughters of Jerusalem then provide a coda, speaking for all when they call on the couple to drink deeply from the well of their love (5:1e-f).

[Husband:]

4:1a Oh, you are beautiful, my friend;

4:1b Oh, you are beautiful!

4:1c Your eyes are doves

4:1d Behind your veil.

4:1e Your hair is like a flock of goats

4:1f That playfully make their way down [the slopes of] Mount Gilead.

4:2a Your teeth are like a shorn flock

4:2b That comes away from washing,

4:2c For all of them are twins,

4:2d And none is bereaved [of its partner].

4:3a Like a scarlet cord are your lips,

4:3b And your mouth is lovely;

4:3c Like a slice of pomegranate

4:3d Is your forehead behind your veil.

4:4a Like the tower of David is your neck,

4:4b Built in courses.

4:4c A thousand in number are the shields hung upon it;

4:4d [A thousand in number are] all the javelins of the warriors.

4:5a Your two breasts are like two fawns,

4:5b Twins of a gazelle,

4:5c Grazing among the asphodels.

4:6a Until the wind dissipates,

4:6b And the shadows flee,

4:6c I will gladly go to the mountain of myrrh,

4:6d And to the hill of frankincense.

4:7a You are wholly beautiful, my friend,

4:7b And there is no blemish in you.

4:8a [Come] with me from Lebanon, O bride!

4:8b Come with me from Lebanon!

4:8c Journey [with me] from Mount Amanah,

4:8d From Mount Senir and [from Mount] Hermon,

4:8e From the dwellings of lions,

4:8f From the mountains of leopards.

4:9a You have stolen my heart, my sister, O bride!

4:9b You have stolen my heart with one glance of your eyes,
 4:9c With one link of your chain necklace.
 4:10a How powerful is your love, my sister, O bride!
 4:10b How much better is your love than wine,
 4:10c And the fragrance of your oils than any spices.
 4:11a Like dripping honey are your lips, O bride.
 4:11b Fig cakes and milk are under your tongue,
 4:11c And the aroma of your garments is like the aroma of Lebanon.
 4:12a A locked garden is my sister, O bride—
 4:12b A locked garden, a sealed spring.
 4:13a Your shoots are a garden of pomegranates,
 4:13b With the finest fruit,
 4:13c [And with] henna plants and nard,
 4:14a Nard and saffron, a spice reed and cinnamon,
 4:14b With all the trees of Lebanon,
 4:14c Myrrh and aloe
 4:14d With all the best balsam.
 4:15a A spring of the gardens [are you],
 4:15b A well with water that is free-flowing
 4:15c And that rushes down from Lebanon [itself].

[Wife:]

4:16a Awake, O north wind,
 4:16b And come, O south wind—
 4:16c Breathe on my garden,
 4:16d That its balsam may flow;
 4:16e Let my beloved come to his garden,
 4:16f And eat of its best fruits.

[Husband:]

5:1a I come to my garden, my sister, O bride;
 5:1b I collect my myrrh with my balsam;
 5:1c I eat my honeycomb with my fig cakes;
 5:1d I drink my wine with my milk.

[Daughters of Jerusalem:]

5:1e Eat, friends;
 5:1f Drink and enjoy, lovers!

Clarifying the Ideas (4:1-5:1)

4:1a my friend: This term does much to frame the relationship in general and this passage in particular (see also 5:1e): The husband's melody is not only marital sexuality, or even only marital romance, but marital friendship.

4:1c Your eyes are doves: As mentioned on a prior occasion, some **doves** in ancient Israel were dark in color, so the reference is probably to the iris.

4:1d your veil: This is not necessarily a wedding veil, for women in ancient Israel wore veils under various circumstances.²¹ Rather, this component of her outfit probably bespeaks an admirable combination of modesty (note the declarations of her good character in 1:4e and in 8:10a) and tasteful style (cf. 4:9c, 7:2a, etc.).

4:1e-f: “In ancient days, the image of black goats descending on a green mountainside was a beautiful sight to the people. They would see someone with beautiful, flowing, black hair—rich and deep like the color of these goats—and they would say, 'Your hair reminds me of a flock of goats moving down the slopes of Gilead.' That was a compliment, not an insult” (Sproul, 45).

4:2 Shepherds love their sheep, and sheep are at their whitest and cleanest after having been shorn and cleaned. Her teeth are to him perfectly formed and white. She has also taken care of them, and so is not

²¹ This point is developed in Appendix 5.

missing any—not something to be taken for granted in a world without toothpaste and floss, especially when we consider all the sand in southern and eastern Israel.

4:3a The cultural background behind this simile is obscure. “However, in the context of a love poem, the intention of the compliment is obvious. She had lovely lips; he desires to kiss them” (Longman, 145).

4:3c-d: Perhaps he is seeing a certain similarity of shape and curvature between her cheeks and a pomegranate. Additionally, pomegranates seem to have had romantic connotations in that culture, rather like red roses today.

4:4b The imagery refers “to the individual well arranged rows of rectangular ashlar blocks with which the tower is constructed and which underlie its unshakeable security” (Koehler & Baumgartner, 2:1741). The reference behind the imagery might be to a multi-hooped necklace. In any case, by alluding to the holy city and to the first great king of God’s people the husband ascribes tremendous value to his wife.

4:4c One can imagine a pristine tower lined with dazzling silver shields of valiant defenders of the kingdom, these shields glinting in the golden sun. Such is the image the husband gets when he sees her necklace.

4:4d javelins: In its best moments, ancient Israel did not celebrate unnecessary war or exploitative imperialism (e.g., Ps 120:7). Nevertheless, military action was at times necessary, not least in the days of David, and the valor and devotion of David’s best warriors amazed even him (e.g., 2 Sam 23:15-17).

4:5a breasts: On the lack of a shock value for the original readership in the use of the word “breasts,” see “Clarifying the Ideas” on 1:13b. The husband’s language here is certainly intimate, but not overbold. Prominent in the idea of Hebrew word (עֵפֶר) translated **fawns** is that of youthfulness (cf. Koehler & Baumgartner 1:862^b; Jastrow 1055^b-1056^a), and that aspect of youthfulness which in this context seems to be on his mind is that of playful (**grazing among the asphodels** suggests a time of security and recreation) energy (the **gazelle** is an animal which leaps and bounds, especially when young).

4:6a-b Until the wind dissipates: Either a reference to regular evening breezes in Israel, or to a storm from which the couple takes refuge in the safety of their bedroom. In the latter case, the storm is probably not literal, or even necessarily indicative of some problem in their environment, but either a foil for the peace of their relationship or an enchanting backdrop for their enchanted relationship. **And the shadows flee:** In other words, “And [until] morning comes,” “All night long.” Deer (see lines c-d) are largely nocturnal, a fact might have motivated this choice of language. Of course, this imagery can also allude subtly to certain other nocturnal activities.

4:6c-d: The **mountains** are of course figurative, bespeaking the majestic beauty of their love. That these peaks flow with such exotic items as **myrrh** and **frankincense** underscores the other-worldly nature of the hoped-for (and granted, 4:16) experience.

4:8 The husband uses powerful imagery drawn from the mightiest of geographic features familiar to him (for example, Mount **Hermon**, though part of the State of Israel, gets plenty of snow) in order to cast the metaphorical journey he envisions in the most compelling of terms.

4:9a sister: This word is not used literally, but as a term of affection. There are rough analogues in various modern cultures.

4:10c your oils: That is, the perfume oils with which she has anointed herself.

4:11b With his reference to **fig cakes** the husband invokes the pleasure of a sweet dessert, and with his reference to **milk**, he invests his wife with a strengthening force.

4:12a-b a locked garden... a sealed spring: As in 1:8, the husband expresses to his wife his confidence that she is exclusively his, comparing her love to a private garden with water inaccessible to the public.

4:13a Your shoots: The wife is being compared to a garden (note the previous verse), and a thriving garden includes **shoots**, that is, the new tendrils reaching out from their starting point to expand the scope of the plant. These **shoots** themselves are said to be a **garden**, though here a different Hebrew word is used (not גן as in v12, but פֶּרֶס). **Pomegranates** were something of a delicacy. Every aspect of his wife is exquisite.

4:13c henna: As mentioned as it relates to 1:14a, these flowers produce a dye with which women could create body art via temporary tattoos. The husband thus ascribes an artistic quality to his wife’s body; in a sense, she *is* art.

4:13c nard: An aromatic plant from South Asia.

4:14a saffron: Nowadays at least, **saffron** is by weight the most expensive spice in the world.

Similar luxury is to be found in a **spice reed** and in **cinnamon**.

4:14b the trees of Lebanon: These were tremendously impressive to ancient Israelites.

4:16c my garden: In response to her husband's words (v14a-b), the wife uses garden language to describe her most intimate affections.

4:16d That its balsam may flow: Koehler & Baumgartner (1:163^b) note that balsam oil “easily coagulates”; possibly she takes his earlier (v14d) use of **balsam** and here highlights a different aspect of it (viz. he had in mind its delectable aroma and striking taste; she thinks of its challenging nature) to signal her disinclination to agree with his astonishing assessment of her. Nevertheless, she wishes to be pleasing to him: v14 does not see her giving up, but rather calling (in poetic language) for an interposition of grace to enable her, and inviting her husband to her side.

4:16e his garden: Here the wife still uses **garden** to mean to what she meant by it in line c above. But by the change in possessive pronoun, she transfers ownership from herself to him (cf. 1 Cor 7:4).

5:1e-f: Little about Song of Songs is literal, so the Daughters of Jerusalem need not necessarily be thought of as eavesdropping on an intimate conversation. Their outsider perspective, however, affirms the commendable nature of the husband-wife relationship rehearsed in the preceding lines, and assists those readers of the book who are married to internalize the application: Drink deeply from your love!

Notes on Some Details (4:1-5:1)

4:1d your veil: See further Appendix 6.

4:1f that playfully make their way down: In Hebrew this is a single word (שגלשו); it is difficult to find an English verb that is suitable both for a woman's hair and for a flock of goats (perhaps in part because our language has for so long inhabited post-industrial cultures).

4:4c javelins: See Koehler & Baumgartner, 2:1523^b.

4:5a Your two breasts: Contours being what they are, only the most radical style of clothing would disguise the fact—and there is no scandal here—that a grown woman has breasts. Alternatively, he refers to what he, as her husband, has seen on prior occasions.

4:6c gladly: A paraphrase of לי (as imparting energy to the verb אֵלֶךְ).

4:8a bride: This word does not necessarily imply that he and she had been wed that very day (in English, too, “bride” is sometimes used affectionately long after the ceremony). Its presence here is part of a larger piling-on of terms of endearment for the wife (“friend,” 4:1a; “my sister,” 4:9a), similar to what happens elsewhere (e.g., “my friend, / My beautiful one,” 2:10b-c); it might also be a subtle criticism of King Solomon's marriage in 3:7-11, for unlike that monarch, the husband of this wife has only one bride.²²

4:8c journey: The meaning of the Hebrew (תשורי) is uncertain.

4:9a, b You have stolen my heart: The meaning of the Hebrew (לבבתי) is uncertain (a similar thought seemingly occurs in 6:5b, though the Hebrew there is also obscure).

4:10a powerful: On this (late) meaning of the Hebrew (יפה), cf. Jastrow, 585^b-586^a.

4:11b fig cakes: The exact meaning is unclear, but some sort of dessert or sweetener made from dates (or possibly grapes) seems to be meant (cf. Jastrow, 279^a; Koehler & Baumgartner, 1:212^b-213^a, and 5:1c, where, for reasons that need not detain us here, the meaning “fig cakes” seems more probable than “honey”).

4:12a-b: These lines are often interpreted as referring to her virginity, but (1) she was probably not a virgin at this point, since as mentioned in the Introduction (“Are the Two Main Characters Married to Each Other?”), she is probably depicted as married to her husband from the beginning of the book; the same word for “garden” (גן) appears twice in v16, echoing the husband's words but in a way that relates it not to virginity but to her love / her body; and (3) the word just mentioned recurs in 6:2a in a way that is reminiscent of this passage and which hardly refers to virginity.²³

²² This note of criticism might explain why, unusually for the husband, there is no “my” affixed to the term (“my bride”): If the poet had written “my bride,” the Hebrew (כלתי) could, depending on what vowels the readers mentally supplied, also be read as “my brides” (something King Solomon could say), while the simple form “bride” (כלה) occasions no ambiguity. (It is true that in Hebrew there would be ways to say something like “my one bride” unambiguously, but such would have been (1) cumbersome for the meter and (2) too heavy-handed for a poet who elsewhere places great confidence in his or her readers' ability to discern the narratives, tones, and lessons embedded in the fabric of the work.)

²³ The same word occurs also in 4:15a, 5:1a, 6:2c, and 8:13a; a very similar word (גנה) occurs in 6:11a. A conceptually

4:12b garden: The masoretic reading (גל) is likely due to anticipation of the final letter of the word גִּדּוּל shortly to be repeated. This verse employs a form of the pattern A + X / A + B, a common one in Song of Songs.

4:15c Lebanon: Another possible rendering is “the mountains of Lebanon.”

5:1a-d I understand the suffix-tense Hebrew verbs in these lines as performative (cf. Cowley, §106i(b) 311-312), seeing in the husband's words reassurance (see “Clarifying the Message” on this verse). If instead the significance of the tense forms here is past action (“I have come,” “I have collected,” etc.), then these lines represent a literary flash-forward, with the husband looking back on the interaction.

5:1f enjoy: Literally, “drink wine” (שָׁכַר), but since it is hard to capture the tone with a literal English translation, and since wine is a luxury item, I paraphrase thus.

Considering the Message (4:1-5:1)

This is the husband's longest speech, and in that sense at least it is something of a high point in the book. His words of praise for his wife are unstinting. He speaks of her beauty (4:1a-7b), of his longing for a journey of love with her (4:8a-f), of her hold over his heart (4:9a-10c), of her ethereal qualities (4:11a-14d), and of her fidelity to him (4:15a-c). Here is a man who has pondered Pr 18:22 (“he who finds a wife has found something good, and has obtained favor from Yahweh”). While his words are surely charged with a sexual undercurrent, any fair reading of the husband's words in this passage must lead to the conclusion that he longs for more than merely her body, as if her physical elements, separate from her emotions, her mind, and her spirit, could in themselves satisfy his longing. What he desires—and what she makes clear that she hopes to give to him (4:16a-f)—is herself, as a whole person, her body included (cf. the comments on 4:1a under “Clarifying the Ideas”). Further, he makes no rough demands, but makes an appeal framed with care and with imagination. True love is holistic and artistic.

God's love for his church is cut from the same cloth: He saves body, soul, and spirit (1 Thes 5:23), and the story of his redemption of his people—a story that unfolds from Genesis to Revelation—is told with verve, with suspense, with irony, with intensity, with grandeur, and with tenderness.

Translation (5:2-6:3)

As in 3:1-4, the wife has a dream (5:2-7), in which her husband comes to the door, asking to be let in, but she refuses. After this dream she adjures the Daughters of Jerusalem (5:8). This second dream has a more negative outcome than the first did, but it does provide a springboard for constructive dialogue, for the Daughters of Jerusalem ask the wife what is so special about her man (5:9), and she answers this question at length (5:10-16). The Daughters of Jerusalem inquire further about the nature of the relationship (6:1), leading her to affirm the assured reality of their bond (6:2-3).

[Wife:]

5:2a I was sleeping, but my mind was awake.

5:2b The sound of my beloved knocking [at the door].

5:2c [He said,] “Open for me, my sister,

5:2d “My friend, my dove, my perfect one!

5:2e “For my head is full of dew,

5:2f “[And] my locks [are full] of [water] droplets.”

5:3a I have [already] taken off my dress—

5:3b How can I put it on [again]?

5:3c I have [already] washed my feet—

5:3d How can I dirty them [again]?

5:4a My beloved withdrew his hand from the hole,

5:4b And my feelings were stirred for him.

5:5a I arose to open [the door] for my beloved,

5:5b And my hands dripped with myrrh,

5:5c And my hands [dripped] with flowing myrrh

5:5d On the handles of the [door's] lock.

5:6a I opened for my beloved,

similar word, “vineyard” (כרם), occurs in 1:6d, e, v14b, 2:15b, c, 7:13a, 8:11a, b, and v12a.

5:6b But my beloved had gone out of sight.
 5:6c My soul had gone out with his words;
 5:6d [Yet] I searched for him but did not find him,
 5:6e [And] I called to him but he did not answer me.
 5:7a The sentries who go around the city found me;
 5:7b They hit me; they struck me; the wall-sentries pulled my shawl off.
 5:8a I adjure you, Daughters of Jerusalem,
 5:8b If you find my beloved,
 5:8c Tell him that I am lovesick.
 [Daughters of Jerusalem, to the wife:]
 5:9a What makes your beloved so special,
 5:9b Most beautiful among women?
 5:9c What makes your beloved so special,
 5:9d That thus you adjure us?
 [Wife:]
 5:10a My beloved is bright and ruddy,
 5:10b Outshining a myriad.
 5:11a His head is pure gold;
 5:11b His hair is wavy,
 5:11c Black like a raven.
 5:12a His eyes are like doves
 5:12b On streams of water,
 5:12c Bathing in the foaming water,
 5:12d [And] sitting on a rim.
 5:13a His cheeks are like a bed of balsam,
 5:13b [A garden fruitfully] growing herbs.
 5:13c His lips are like asphodels, dripping with flowing myrrh.
 5:14a His arms are like golden rods,
 5:14b Set with topaz.
 5:14c His abdomen is an ivory bar,
 5:14d Covered with lapis lazuli.
 5:15a His thighs are columns of alabaster,
 5:15b Set on pedestals of pure gold.
 5:15c His appearance is like Lebanon,
 5:15d As excellent as the cedars [of Lebanon].
 5:16a His taste is altogether sweet,
 5:16b And his whole person is altogether desirable.
 5:16c This is my beloved,
 5:16d And this is my friend,
 5:16e O Daughters of Jerusalem.
 [Daughters of Jerusalem, to wife:]
 6:1a Where has your beloved gone, most beautiful among women?
 6:1b Where has your beloved gone, that we may seek him with you?
 [Wife, to the Daughters of Jerusalem:]
 6:2a My beloved has gone to his garden;
 6:2b [My beloved has gone] to his balsam beds,
 6:2c To cultivate the garden,
 6:2d And to gather asphodels.
 6:3a I am my beloved's,
 6:3b And my beloved is mine—
 6:3c [My beloved] who shepherds among the asphodels.

Clarifying the Ideas (5:2-6:3)

5:2a I was sleeping, but my mind was awake: That is, “I was dreaming.”

5:3 To her husband's request (2c-f) for her to open the (apparently locked) door, she answers negatively, citing the facts that she is already undressed for bed (and apparently cannot open the door without immodestly exposing herself to neighbors unless she takes the trouble of getting dressed again) and has already washed her feet (getting into bed only after washing one's feet is a cultural practice followed by many people in the world today). While these are certainly inconvenient circumstances, it hardly seems plausible that she really intends to keep her husband outside all night. Granting that dreams are often implausible, perhaps the request for entrance into the house is code for a request for sex, and her response signals a lack of interest. At any rate, there is initially a disconnect between his wishes and her willingness.

5:4a my beloved: That the wife characterizes her husband this way shows that they are not utterly estranged; whatever friction has just been described is not an insurmountable obstacle in her mind.

5:4a the hole: It is not clear to me whether this term here refers to some regular architectural feature (a small window?) or to some gap in the door or wall (because they were poor?).

5:5b And my hands dripped with myrrh: This is a strange detail indeed, at least if taken literally. Among the possibilities is that it is some figure of speech. Another possibility is that it is meant literally, but this within the framework of the dream sequence, and as mentioned dreams are often strange and unpredictable. Either way, **myrrh** is several times in the Song of Songs associated with the husband (e.g. 5:13c), so while the details of the poet's literary strategy are unclear, the effect of it is to evoke positive feelings for the husband.

5:6c My soul had gone out with his words: The Hebrew is obscure, but I take it to mean that as her husband spoke, she began to feel her emotions shift from apathy to affection.

5:10a ruddy: That is, somewhat red-complexioned in the face, a desirable trait for men in ancient Jewish culture (cf. 1 Sam 16:12).

5:12a Some **doves** in ancient Israel were a dark color.

5:13c: The coolness of his **lips** (perhaps she is thinking of when they kiss) is as precious as **myrrh**.

5:13a-b Men in ancient Israel were seemingly always bearded. Perhaps the fine hairs on his cheeks make her think of the soft, intricate beauty of the forest floor, many small strands of plant life nestled together. Some of these small plants would be **herbs**, many of which bear a pleasant aroma. This fact adds to the appropriateness of her metaphor, since she likes the way her husband smells.

5:14c His abdomen is an ivory bar: Thus combining strength with a delicacy (**ivory** is carveable).

5:14c-d ivory... lapis lazuli: The first item hails from India and the second from Afghanistan, making these dazzling comparisons.

5:15a His thighs: That is, the upper part of his legs. **are alabaster columns:** Thighs are visually and functionally comparable to the columns that hold up a structure. But since **alabaster**, a carveable substance used by artisans, is the material she envisions, it is evident that she has in mind not brute strength but magnificence.

5:15b Set on pedestals of pure gold: In this context (see the preceding note), the **pedestals** represent the lower parts of his legs, themselves exquisite finery (**pure gold**).

5:16a His taste: The Hebrew is a bit obscure, but the idea here seems to be “the experience of knowing him” (cf. Ps 34:9, “Taste and see that the Lord is good”).

Notes on Some Details (5:2-6:3)

5:2a mind: Hebrew does not have a word for “mind.” Instead, it uses words like “heart” (לב, as here, or לבב) or “internal organs” (כליות).

5:4b And my feelings were stirred for him: I borrow this rendering from the CSB.

5:6b had gone out of sight: The Hebrew is a bit obscure, but this seems to be the sense (a more literal rendering might be “had turned away, had gone beyond,” or “had crossed over a curve,” i.e. “had gone around the corner [of the block]”).

5:7b shawl: The exact meaning of this Hebrew word (רדיד) is uncertain.

5:9b, d: More literally, “What is your beloved more than any given beloved?” They are not suggesting that she has ever had more than one man in her life, only asking what makes her beloved unique.

5:11a pure gold: The meaning of the Hebrew (כתם פז) is uncertain.

5:11b His hair is wavy: The meaning of the Hebrew (קוצותיו תלתלים) is uncertain; I borrow the CSB

rendering, which seems plausible.

5:12c the foaming waters: On this rendering of the Hebrew (בִּחְלָב) see Tawil 2012 (209-213).

5:12d [and] sitting on a rim: The meaning of the Hebrew (יֹשְׁבוֹת עַל מְלָאָה) is uncertain.

5:13a His cheeks are: Or possibly, “His chin is” (Koehler & Baumgartner, 1:525^a).

5:16a His taste: Or possibly “his mouth.”

6:1b gone: A different Hebrew verb than in the previous line, but I'm not sure English has enough verbs that are helpful in this regard.

Considering the Message (5:2-6:3)

It is difficult to know whether the dream sequence in 5:1-7 reflects some real fracture in the relationship, or only the fear of such. If a real fracture is depicted, then reconciliation occurs at or before 6:2. If the dream was only fear, 6:2 speaks to reality. Either way, the relationship proves stronger than real or imagined dysfunction. What eventually (6:3) rounds out this section is a reaffirmation (cf. 2:16) of their mutual commitment. Commitment creates continuity; fear must never be the focus.

Not content to be defined by the conflict sketched in 5:1-7, this wife is determined “to respect her husband” (Eph 5:33 CSB). Her description of her husband (5:10-16) is truly unrestrained: In her mind's eye, her husband combines in himself the contrasting but equally striking qualities of ravens (5:11c) and of doves (5:12a), of plant life (5:13) and of mineral wealth (5:13), of far-off realms (like Afghanistan, 5:13) and of comparatively local sites (like Lebanon, 5:14). If her self-image is at times deficient (1:6-7), his might be too. A married man needs his wife's help (cf. Gen 2:18), and part of her assistance is affirmation.

What's more, the wife quite deliberately cultivates the relationship to which she has committed (6:3). “[O]ur choices go a long way toward determining the direction and depth of our relationships. We can choose words that encourage and uplift or words that tear down and humiliate... We can focus on the ways in which our spouse is a good gift to us, or we can constantly criticize and complain. We can make choices at work, in ministry, and in social settings that reinforce our faithfulness, or we can make choices that put that in jeopardy” (Curtis, 162). This wife has chosen the better way (cf. 1 Cor 12:31).

Translation (6:4-9)

The husband once again praises his wife's qualities.

[Husband, to wife:]

6:4a You are as beautiful, my friend, as Tirzah,

6:4b As lovely as Jerusalem, awe-inspiring as an army with banners unfurled.

6:5a Turn your gaze from me,

6:5b For it has overwhelmed me.

6:5c Your hair is like a flock of goats

6:5d That playfully make their way down [the slopes of] Mount Gilead.

6:6a Your teeth are like a flock of ewe-lambs

6:6b That comes away from washing,

6:6c For all of them are twins,

6:6d And none is bereaved [of its partner].

6:7a Like a slice of pomegranate

6:7b Is your forehead behind your veil.

6:8a There are sixty queens,

6:8b And eighty concubines,

6:8c And young women without number.

6:9a My dove, my perfect one, is one!

6:9b [Also] to her mother she is one;

6:9c Pure to her who gave her birth.

6:9d Women have seen her and count her blessed;

6:9e Queens and concubines [have seen her], and praised her.

Clarifying the Ideas (6:4-9)

6:4a Tirzah: Tirzah was a city. Its name roughly means “beauty” in Hebrew (תִּרְצָה). It was a site of such

renown that for a time it stood as the capital of the Northern Kingdom of Israel.

6:5a-b: Or, to paraphrase, “Your eyes hold me in a trance.”

6:5c-d As remarked on with reference to 4:1, the impact of the simile is appreciable if one pictures oneself on the mountain slopes of Israel, looking across at a rugged descent a few miles off, at which descent a shepherd is leading a large flock of goats downhill. It would be difficult to discern individual animals; rather, what one's eye would capture is the soft texture of the flock, and the joyful, bounding motion of the goats boldly leaping from point to point. Similar, says the husband, is the sight of his wife's hair: The many strands flow together, yet each jerks with a happy bounce when she moves her head, an entrancing cascade of texture and movement.

6:6 Shepherds love their sheep, and sheep are at their whitest and cleanest after having been shorn and cleaned. Her teeth are to him perfectly formed and white.

6:8 The polygamy and extramarital sexuality activity of Solomon is not mentioned in order to signal approval for it, but rather to set up a contrast (see the following verse).

Notes on Some Details (6:4-9)

6:5 overwhelmed me: The meaning of the Hebrew (הרהיבני) is uncertain.

6:9 one: There is an ambiguity in the Hebrew as to whether “one” (אחת) means “one in number” or “utterly unique.” This ambiguity is probably intentional, the author pivoting from the idea of arithmetic in the previous verse to the idea of quality in this verse.

Considering the Message (6:4-9)

Tied in to the husband's continued praise of his wife is his fidelity to his wife. The king has his pick of women, but there is no need for a smorgasbord: This husband is awestruck by his wife. Other husbands would do well to take the same point of view with respect to their own wives.

While the primary intent of 6:9e is to elevate the wife (on the logic that even those who live in royal palaces have reason to be impressed), the author's approach here also avoids a common error, namely the notion that women who have been used as sexual objects (here, queens and concubines) have nothing to contribute to society. On the contrary, their voices remain valuable. Tragically, victims of rape, sexual abuse, or sexual coercion often face recrimination, while male perpetrators go free; such an outcome is altogether unjust and unbiblical (cf. Dt 1:17, 22:26-27 etc.). To be clear, women who willfully misuse their sexuality do incur guilt before God, but even in these cases appeal to Jesus Christ for mercy will thoroughly clean their sin—whatever prejudices against them remain for a time on earth (cf. Lk 7:36-48). All human beings, whatever their past, deserve genuine respect.

Translation (6:10-7:10)

Another riddle draws attention to the wife (6:10). The husband reflects upon a prior experience in which he sought his wife's affections (v11) and found them, seemingly beyond even his expectations (v12). The Daughters of Jerusalem, as often, indicate their high regard for the wife (v13a-b); their call not only reinforces the wife's standing in her community, but also provides a convenient pivot point for the husband again to invoke the exclusivity of the relationship (6:13c-d), and to go on with another catalog of his wife's perfections (7:1a-7:9a). He is seemingly interrupted by his wife, who intertwines his and her pleasure (7:9b-c) and reaffirms their mutual ownership (7:10).

[Daughters of Jerusalem, concerning the wife:]

6:10a Who is this who looks down [at the earth below] like Dawn,

6:10b As beautiful as Lebanon, as bright as the sun,

6:10c Awe-inspiring as an army with banners unfurled.

[Husband:]

6:11a I went down to the walnut orchard,

6:11b To examine the shoots of the wadi,

6:11c [And] to see whether the vine had sprouted,

6:11d And [whether] the pomegranate has bloomed.

6:12a Before I knew it,

6:12b She had set me among the [very] chariots of Amminadab.

[Daughters of Jerusalem:]

6:13a Return, return, O Shulammite!

6:13b Return, return, that we may gaze upon you!

[Husband, to Daughters of Jerusalem:]

6:13c Do not gaze upon the Shulammite,

6:13d As on the *Machanayim* Dance!

[Husband, to wife:]

7:1a How beautiful are your feet in sandals, princess!

7:1b Your thighs are like *chala'im*,

7:1c The work of a [true] craftsman's hands.

7:2a Your navel is a rounded bowl—

7:2b May it never lack mixed wine!

7:2c Your belly is a mound of wheat,

7:2d Surrounded by asphodels.

7:3a Your two breasts are like two fawns,

7:3b Twins of a gazelle.

7:4a Your neck is like an ivory tower.

7:4b Your eyes are wells in Heshbon,

7:4c By the Bathrabbim Gate.

7:4d Your nose is like the tower of Lebanon,

7:4e Looking toward Damascus.

7:5a Your head is like Carmel,

7:5b And the hair of your head is like purple—

7:5c The king is held captive in your tresses!

7:6a How beautiful and how pleasant you are,

7:6b O beloved who is so delightful!

7:7a Your stature is like a date-palm tree,

7:7b And your breasts [are] like clusters [of dates].

7:8a I think to myself, “I will climb the date-palm tree;

7:8b I will take hold of the fronds”—

7:8c And may your breasts be like clusters of the grape vine,

7:8d And [may] the fragrance of your breath [be] like apples,

7:9a And [may] your mouth [be] like the best wine...

[Wife, to/of husband:]

7:9b ...Flowing smoothly for my beloved,

7:9c Gliding over the lips of the sleepers!

7:10a I am my beloved's,

7:10b And his desire is for me.

Clarifying the Ideas (6:10-7:10)

6:10a who looks down [at the earth below] like Dawn: The wife is compared to a personified morning sun as it rises up into the sky, shedding its glory on all the distant (and small by comparison) people and places of the earth.

6:11 The husband set out to see where their relationship stood.

6:12a-b Before I knew it, / She had set me among the [very] chariots of Amminadab: This verse is famous among scholars for its obscurity. In context, it seems to speak of a positive outcome to his just-stated (v11) inquiry. The pronoun **She** refers to the wife.

6:13b As on the *Machanayim* Dance?: This might refer to some eye-catching dance. Or perhaps it is a reference to the presence of angels in Mahanaim (another spelling of the same term) recorded in Gen 32:1-2, as if you say, “As enraptured as if you were watching angels in all their heavenly splendor?” Either way, he is paying his wife a compliment.

6:13c Do not gaze: This is not to be taken overly literally, as if there was something wrong in their enjoyment of his wife's dance or appearance, or as if he is cutting off his wife from friendships (the daughters

of Jerusalem continue to appear as characters in the book). The husband's intent here is to lay claim to the exclusivity that his marriage to his wife entails; there is a sense in which she is his, and not anyone else's (6:3a), and he is sensible enough to celebrate this fact.

7:1a How beautiful are your feet in sandals: Fashionable footwear is biblical!

7:1a princess: She had earlier spoken of him as royalty (1:4b, etc.). Here he returns the favor.

7:1b *chala'im*: Some type of jewelry.

7:2a-b Your navel is a rounded bowl—may it never lack mixed wine!: The metaphor might operate on two levels: Visually, an inward-facing **navel** could resemble a drinking goblet; in terms of association, the exclusivity inherent in this area of her body (standards of clothing in ancient Israel being such that the navel would rarely, if ever, be seen in public) could remind him of the exquisite experience of drinking **mixed wine** (and gourmet beverage reserved, due to its cost, for special occasions).

7:2c Your belly is a mound of wheat: This hardly sounds flattering in American culture, but the gentle texture and curvature and the color of wheat resembles somewhat that of her stomach area. Coming from a society largely subsisting on agriculture, this poetic language probably also bears connotations of abundance and satisfaction.

7:3 See “Clarifying the Ideas” to 4:5.

7:4b Your eyes are wells: They were deep and entrancing, like gently rippling water.

7:4d Your nose is like the tower of Lebanon: If she had a long nose, he did not mind this. The structure mentioned is unknown, but the references to **Lebanon** in this book are overwhelmingly positive.

7:4e Damascus: This city is renowned to the present day for its beauty.

7:5b purple: This color was extraordinarily expensive in ancient times; her hair, then, is to him extraordinarily precious.

7:7-8: The Hebrew does not necessarily imply that the wife is tall, but as his visual tour of her has started with her feet and worked its way up, so his mind now turns to the vertical aspect of a **date-palm tree**. Just as a **date-palm tree** boasts **clusters** of fruit near their tops, so women have **breasts** as part of their upper body; and just as one would in ancient times **climb** to reach the **fruit**, so the husband intends fully to enjoy his wife's body. These verses are some of the most—if not *the* most—sexually charged in Song of Songs, but while that fact should not be forgotten, it is also the case that a great deal more *might* have been said here, but *was not*; the imagery remains veiled. Still, in general terms the bodily unity of husband and wife should not be a secret, for it holds in it a profound mystery (see further Appendix 2).

7:9b-c: The wife either picks up where her husband left off, or interjects her own ending to his words. She is pleased with his train of thought. It should be noted that the Hebrew is very difficult to understand, partly because of a rare verb (דבב), and partly, it seems likely to me, due to some word plays that are hard to trace all these centuries later. Here is an attempt at a paraphrase: “I hope that his experience of our love is delightful as we fade off into blissful sleep in our shared bed.”

7:10b That is to say, “It is *me* that he desires,” said with a tone of satisfaction and security.

Notes on Some Details (6:10-7:10)

6:12 Although this verse is attributed to the wife, I assign the verse to the husband. But I do so tentatively: Any interpretation of this difficult verse is grasping at straws to some extent.

6:12a Before I knew it: I tentatively scan the first poetic line as *לֹא יָדַעְתִּי נַפְשִׁי*,²⁴ and, understanding נַפֶּשׁ (usually rendered “soul”) as here referring to the faculty of felt experience, omit it from the translation, since including it would detract from the clarity of the rendering and from the degree to which the English idiom “before I know it” maps onto the sense of the Hebrew (at least as I understand the passage).

6:12b She: Usually נַפְשִׁי is understood as the subject of the verb שָׁמַחְתִּי, but I think the verse is more coherent if what “had set [him] on the [very] chariots of Amminadab” is not, obliquely, said to be his emotional faculties, but, more directly, his wife.

6:12b [very]: I supply this adverb in an attempt to clarify that (evidently) to be “among the chariots of Amminadab” is a desirable thing.

²⁴ Most English translations group *נַפְשִׁי* with the following line, but I doubt whether *לֹא יָדַעְתִּי* is metrically sufficient for an entire line. (Despite the English translation given above, the Hebrew lines, thus scanned, appear to be well-balanced.)

6:12b Ammindab: The presence of a word divider²⁵ does not preclude the possibility of a personal name (note for example שָׂרִי צוּרִי in Num 2:12). That said, the Hebrew at this point quite possibly is not a name (presumably of some famous person²⁶) but a phrase, viz. “my noble people” (apparently appealing to a well-placed patriotism) or “my noble kinsman” (alluding to royal connections, referring to her husband as if he was a prince or other government official, the kinship tie either being affectionate but not literal, or highlighting their shared Jewish background; the second option seems mostly likely to me).

6:13 This verse is in printed editions of the Hebrew Bible 7:1, while the English 7:1 is in Hebrew 7:2. The English and Hebrew verse numbers continue to differ by one throughout chapter seven, the two traditions uniting again with 8:1. **Do not gaze:** More literally, “Why should you gaze?” But at times, particularly in Song of Songs, this word for “why” (מָה) can be used as a negative (as in 8:4b, with which cf. 2:7c). As mentioned above, the husband is not cutting off his wife from outside friendships. She continues to talk with them after this point in the poem, without any hint of rebuke from her husband. Moreover, he has already affirmed his confidence in her judgment in such passages as 1:8.

7:1a How beautiful are your feet in sandals: Elsewhere in Scripture ostentatious displays are forbidden (1 Pet 3:3), yet attractiveness, accompanied by prudence (cf. Pr 11:22), is seen here to have a place. Human beings are God's handiwork, and it is not his desire for them to be slovenly.

7:1a princess: I borrow this slight paraphrase from the CSB. A more literal rendering would be “daughter of a nobleman” or possibly “noble daughter,” that is, “woman of high character” (taking both “daughter” and “noble” in a figurative sense; on the first of these two terms, cf. “Notes on Some Details” on 2:2b).

7:1b Your thighs: Or possibly “the curves of your thighs” or “the curves of your hips.”

7:1c [true]: This word is supplied to clarify that this is a compliment—he compares her thighs to fine artistry (not to cheap mass-produced products).

7:4e Damascus: Damascus is a Syrian city. This fact, together with the seven mentions of Lebanon in Song of Songs—and these despite the many wars and rivalries that obtained between the ancient Jews and their northern neighbors—shows a lack of ethnocentrism on the part of this poet (at least in his or her best moments, as when the Holy Spirit prompted the penning of this work).

7:5a Your head is like Carmel: More literally, “Your head is upon you like Carmel”; I have paraphrased for stylistic reasons.

7:6b who is so delightful: More literally, “daughter of delights” (cf. Dirksen, 63*). The masoretic text and the Old Greek both witness a faulty word division (בתענוגים) and haplography, whereas the version of Aquila and the Peshitta witness the reading translated here (בת הענוגים).

7:9 In a difficult book, this verse stands out as one of the most difficult. It is often proposed that the masoretic text (שפתי ישנים) is an error for שפתי וישני (reflected in the translation above, with the support of a number of ancient witnesses, most notably the Old Greek version), the *waw* being confused for the similar visually *yodh* and the *mem* added (on the *mem* not being enclitic, see Dirksen, *63) to the resulting senseless *ישני. But the resultant Hebrew is improbable, if not impossible (Cowley, 439 §135m).

Considering the Message (6:10-7:10)

Once again the incalculable value of the wife as a human being is brought into sharp relief (6:10). For a man, being married to a woman is not incidental, but monumental. When this fact is understood, it is in fact unsurprising that the husband's inquiry as to whether there was still love to be found in his marriage (6:11) leads to an answer even more enthralling than he had dared to hope (6:12).

This passage twice (6:13, 7:10) touches directly on the exclusivity of marriage. While husbands in particular must not be controlling (see “Considering the Message” to 2:8-14), there must be boundaries in marriage, a sense in which the husband is his wife's partner before and differently than he is anyone else's, and a sense in which the wife is her husband's partner before and differently than she is anyone else's. Similarly, Christians are “in the world” (Jn 17:11) but not “of the world” (v14). We are the world's in that we

²⁵ Though some manuscripts have עמינדיב, the best manuscripts seem to have עמי נדיב.

²⁶ Mitchell (1029) wonders whether the reference is to a contemporary of David (1 Chron 15:10-11), but it seems a stretch to suppose that of all the illustrious contemporaries of David, this man alone would have “a kind of chariot or a military order of chariots... named after him” (Mitchell, 1029) and be mentioned in this connection in Song of Songs—especially if, as seems all but certain (see Appendix 1), Song of Songs long postdates that era.

live in it and we are its salt and light (Mat 5:13-14), but we are Christ's in that we have been redeemed by his blood (1 Pet 1:18-19), and he is coming for us (Jn 14:18).

The husband's praise of his wife in 7:2a-10a repeats some of his earlier statements, but much of what he says is new. He also takes a fresh vantage point: While in chapters four and six he more or less started his description of her with her head and worked his way down, stopping part way in his description, here he begins with her feet and works his way up, not stopping part way. In short, this section demonstrates the freshness that characterizes a godly marriage bed. It will continue to have familiar themes, but it will discover new delights. Its pleasure will become fuller with time.

Translation (7:11-8:4)

The wife now takes the initiative in inviting a metaphorical journey of love (7:11a-d), promising her husband the free gift of her own love (7:12e-17d). She goes on to wish that all circumstances could be favorable to the showering of her affections upon him (8:1-3). For a third and final time she urges her friends to embark on their own journeys of love only when the time is right (8:4).

[Wife:]

7:11a Come, my beloved, let us go into the fields,

7:11b Let us spend the night among the henna plants.

7:12a Let us arise early and go to the vineyards—

7:12b Let us see whether the vine has sprouted,

7:12c [And whether] the young fruit has bloomed,

7:12d [And whether] the pomegranates have budded.

7:12e There I will give you my love.

7:13a The mandrakes have given forth their fragrance,

7:13b And on our doorway is every excellent thing,

7:13c [Both] new and old,

7:13d Which I have stored up for you, my beloved.

8:1a Oh, how I wish that that you were my brother,

8:1b Who had nursed at the breasts of my mother:

8:1c [Then] I would find you outside, [and] I would kiss you,

8:1d And no one would despise me either.

8:2a [Then] I would lead you to the house of my mother who reared me;

8:2b I would give you spiced wine to drink,

8:2c [And] pomegranate must.

8:3a Let his left hand be under my head,

8:3b And his right hand embrace me!

8:4a I adjure you, Daughters of Jerusalem,

8:4b Not to stir up or awaken love

8:4c Until it pleases.

Clarifying the Ideas (7:11-8:4)

7:11-13: In the literary context of Song of Songs, the wife's words here are probably not to be taken literally—what she seeks is not a rural vacation, but an experience of love with him.

7:13b-c She has decorated the **doorway** in a way that recognizes the value that comes from diverse perspectives (**new and old**).

8:1 Cultures around the world vary widely as to what behaviors are acceptable in public. For instance, I've been told that in India today it is widely considered unacceptable for husbands and wives to hold hands in public. In ancient Israel, a married couple kissing would have been considered far too sexual to be found outside the bedroom. On the other hand, siblings in that culture could freely kiss each other as a sign of affection comparable to hugging in America today. Hence the wife momentarily wishes that her husband was instead her brother, so that she could immediately and publicly shower affection upon him. The point is that she loves to show affection to him, and she wishes she could do so in all circumstances.

8:2a I would lead you to the house of my mother who reared me: In ancient Israel, family was virtually unsurpassed in its perceived importance. Even locations associated with family had tremendous

sentimental value, explaining the importance of this particular house in her mind. The closest equivalent in American culture would be the location where a marriage proposal was made.

8:2c pomegranate must: Roughly speaking, this is a kind of juice.

Notes on Some Details (7:11-8:4)

7:11 On the versification, see “Notes on Some Details” on 6:13 above.

7:11b among the henna plants: This could also be rendered “in the villages” (due to a homophone in Hebrew), but henna fits the bucolic imagery of the book as a whole and of this passage in particular.

7:13d The Hebrew word order puts “my beloved” at the front of the line, but this makes for awkward English.

8:4b The wording varies from that of 2:7 and 3:5, but in a way that is difficult to render in English.

Considering the Message (7:11-8:4)

The wife is not a passive partner. She feels free to initiate expressions of love, and does so with creativity (note, for example, **henna**, on which see “Clarifying the Ideas” to 1:14a, and **every excellent thing, [both] new and old**).

While the joining of a man to a woman forms a distinct family unit (Gen 2:24), and while Song of Songs does much to emphasize that point, it is also the case that ideally a married man and woman retain respect, affection, and memories of their family, especially their parents (SS 8:1b, 2a). Agur has some frightening words for those who disrespect their parents (Pr 30:17)!

Due affection for parents does not for this couple interfere with their own intimacy, however (SS 8:3). There is a time for everything (Ecc 3:1), not least sex with one's spouse (1 Cor 7:2).

The passage ends with the third of three (2:7, 3:5, 8:4) calls for the Daughters of Jerusalem to wait for the proper time. “It is easy for people to become so enamored with the delight of romance and the desire for intimacy that they try to force commitment through sex or some other means. People... pursue excitement or passion, only to discover they were pursuing a mirage” (Curtis, 160).

Translation (8:5-10)

Another riddle directs attention to the wife (8:5a-b), after which she looks with satisfaction on a special time of love with her beloved (v5c-e). She calls for his identity to be wrapped up in her (v6a-b), declaring the all-shattering power of love (v6c-7b), which cannot be bought (v7c-d). She reflects on her journey to this point, noting that in her youth her brothers were at pains to ensure her virginity until marriage (v8a-9d). She did indeed maintain her virginity as she grew into womanhood (v10a), and it was precisely in such circumstances that she found herself the object of her husband's esteem (v10b).

[Daughters of Jerusalem, concerning the wife:]

8:5a Who is this coming up from the desert,

8:5b Leaning on her beloved?

[Wife:]

8:5c Under the apple tree I aroused you—

8:5d There your mother was in labor with you;

8:5e There she who gave you birth was in labor [with you].

8:6a Place me like a seal on your heart,

8:6b Like a seal on your arm.

8:6c For love is as strong as death;

8:6d Passion is as powerful as Sheol;

8:6e Its tendrils—tendrils of fire are its flames.

8:7a A mighty torrent cannot quench love,

8:7b Nor can rivers sweep it away.

8:7c If a man were to sell all the treasures of his household for love,

8:7d People would utterly despise him.

8:8- [In my youth my brothers thought to themselves,]

8:8a “We have a little sister,

8:8b “And she does not [yet] have breasts;

8:8c “What will we do for our sister
8:8d “On the day when someone asks to marry her?”
8:9a “If she is a wall,
8:9b “We will build for her a silver battlement;
8:9c “But if she is a door,
8:9d “We will build for her a cedar plank.”
8:10a I was a wall, and my breasts were like towers;
8:10b Then I was in his eyes like one who finds peace.

Clarifying the Ideas (8:5-10)

8:5c-e: The wife attaches great significance to the place (**under the apple tree**) where her husband was born; cf. the comments on 8:2a under “Clarifying the Ideas” to 7:11-8:4 above.

8:6a Place me like a seal on your heart: The **seal** was in ancient Israel a valuable tool by which other objects were marked as the property of the bearer of the seal. Partial modern analogues would be the driver's license, the display of which in the United States verifies one's identity; or the company chop, which in some Asian countries stands in for the individual or for the institution in important documentation. So for the wife to ask her husband to consider her a **seal** on his **heart** is a request for her to be so valuable to him that she in effect is that by which he is known in the public and legal sphere. A wife ought to be no accessory, but an indispensable and defining part of her husband's life.

8:8-10: The brothers declare that if their sister resists the approaches of unscrupulous men (a **wall** does not let people through), they will reward her (with a **silver battlement**), but if she lets people use her body before marriage (an open **door** lets people through), they will take special measures (possibly confinement in the house, something practiced in parts of the world at times today) to keep her from contact with other men (a **cedar plank**). She declares that she kept herself from men (**I was a wall** in keeping with the imagery the brothers used in the previous verse) even as she matured bodily (**my breasts became like towers**, again using the imagery of herself as a city). Because she did this (**then**), she earned her future husband's (**in his eyes**) admiration: The Hebrew word for **peace** connotes that which is whole, complete, and good; his interest in her was based on a positive assessment of her character.

Notes on Some Details (8:5-10)

8:5d, e was in labor: The meaning of this Hebrew verb (חבל) is debated. It might mean here “conceived,” but the evidence for this meaning is not strong in my view, while the sense of childbirth is well-established.

8:6b Passion: This word (קנאה) could also mean “jealousy,” and perhaps the two cannot here be disentangled. But “jealousy” is probably not the principal idea here, for the main intent of this particular monologue is not to impel the husband to fidelity, but to celebrate the power of love.

8:6b powerful: Literally “hard,” but קשה can bear the nuance of intensity (cf. Brown, Driver, & Briggs, 904^{a-b} and cf. Isa 27:1).

8:6e fire, a conflagration: See Appendix 7 for discussion.

8:8d Since this is an idiom, I paraphrase.

8:10b peace: The Hebrew word here (שלום) is similar to the name “Solomon” (שלמה). If that is the intended link, this could either be a subtle indication that Solomon is the husband in this poem, or a subtle jibe: Solomon's name might mean something like “peace,” but true peace is to be found in the principle of this book, not in that monarch's lifestyle. Alternatively, the word שלום might be a playful signature from Shalmah (שלמה)—if indeed a woman by that name authored this poem (see “Introduction, Part 2”).

Considering the Message (8:5-10)

The wording **leaning on her beloved** suggests that the husband is—or is considered by his wife to be—the stronger of the two. There is no shame in this. This is the third of three (3:6a, 6:10a, 8:5a) occurrences of the riddle formula, and in the other two instances the poet uses very powerful language indeed concerning the wife, so it would be unfair to accuse the poet of misogynistic language. In God's economy, the “older shall serve the younger” (Gen 25:23), “many who are... last will be first” (Mat 19:30), and things “that seem to be weaker are indispensable” (1 Cor 12:22 ESV). To try to make women out to be as physically strong as men blurs distinctions that, properly understood, actually point to ways in which God displays his glory to the

world. When God became a man, he was laid in a manger. When he had his kingship proclaimed in Jerusalem, he rode a donkey. When he crushed the power of sin, he did so bleeding on a cross.

That death on the cross is the ultimate example of death-conquering, unquenchable, unpurchasable love. True, our feeble efforts can never approach that love, yet God's Holy Spirit, poured out at Pentecost (Ac 2:16-17), grows love in his people (Gal 5:22). Love can and must characterize wives with regard to their husbands (Tit 2:4), and especially husbands with regard to their wives (Eph 5:25-28). The wife uses imagery of river-resistant flame to make the point that one of the distinguishing features of love is that it persists. The apostle Paul will later concur (1 Cor 13:8).

This woman's brothers might have been overbearing, but in modern America there are many opportunities for young men and women to lose their virginity. One needs to be on one's guard—or rather to take up God's armor—for sin is not only cunning, but destructive (cf. Gen 4:7). Now, it is possible that for some readers of this book, virginity is something that came to an end before marriage. Here 1 Cor 6:9-11 (“Do not be deceived... the sexually immoral... will not inherit the kingdom of God. And such were some of you. Yet you have been washed, yet you have been sanctified, yet you have been justified in the name of the Lord Jesus and in the Spirit of our God”) speaks words of warning to some and words of welcome to others: Those who persist in a lifestyle of sexual wrongdoing are warned that they thereby exclude themselves from God's kingdom; but those who call on the Lord Jesus will be welcomed into the family of God. “The vilest offender who truly believes, that moment from Jesus a pardon receives.”²⁷

Translation (8:11-14)

The wife declares that, in contrast to King Solomon's assets (8:11), her love cannot be bought, but is freely given to her husband (v12). The husband calls for the exclusive, private affections of his wife (v13), who eagerly calls on him to act on his love for her (v14).

[Wife:]

8:11a Solomon had a vineyard in Baal-Hamon.

8:11b He leased the vineyard to keepers;

8:11c Each man would generate a thousand silver with its fruit.

8:12a My vineyard is mine to do with as I wish.

8:12b You keep the thousand, Solomon,

8:12c And let the [vineyard-]keepers have the two hundred.

[Husband:]

8:13a You who dwell in the gardens,

8:13b [My] friends are listening [to the sound of your voice],

8:13c [But] let me be the one to hear your voice!

[Wife:]

8:14a Pass on, my beloved, and be like a gazelle,

8:14b Or like the young [and strong] offspring of the deer

8:14c On the mountains of balsam.

Clarifying the Ideas (8:11-14)

8:11a-12c: Evidently, King Solomon had a practice of renting his vineyards out, either charging two hundred pieces of silver a season for rent and allowing the gardeners to keep the balance (eight hundred pieces of silver, in the instance cited here), or generating a sum of money (one thousand pieces of silver) and allowing the workers to keep a certain portion of that money (whether two hundred as an upward limit, or perhaps one fifth of what was generated). In a figure of speech (analogous to that found in 1:6c-e), the wife shifts the meaning of **vineyard** from a literal one in v11 to a figurative one (her own body and affections) in v12 to make the point that she is not for sale. v12b-c is dismissive: Solomon can keep his money, and the vineyard workers can keep theirs; she does not care, for she has something—love for her husband—that no amount of money can buy.

8:13 You who dwell in the gardens: The husband is addressing his wife. By using this language to refer to her, he seems to suggest that her presence causes her surroundings to bloom into beauty.

8:13b-c: These lines are obscure. The general idea appears to be that the husband longs for a certain

²⁷ The quotation is from the hymn “To God be Glory,” written in 1875 by Fanny Crosby.

exclusivity (cf. 6:13c-d). Others hear her voice, but to him it has a special significance when sent his way.

8:14: Substantially the same answer as in 2:17c-e, though here she mixes the metaphor by invoking **balsam** (a luxury item with strong taste and smell) to heighten the sensory aspects of the experience. As in 1:2a-3a, passionate marital activity framed in terms of pleasurable sensory experiences is the order of the day for this couple.

Notes on Some Details (8:11-14)

8:11a in Baal-Hamon: The author needed some place name here to fill out the meter (and perhaps also to increase vividness through particularity). Solomon likely owned many such vineyards; the decision to single out Baal-Hamon might be to associate that monarch with negative items to help prepare the way for the contrast between him and the wife featured in the poem: The “Baal” component of the place name likely originally referred to an infamous false deity, while “Hamon,” means “wealth,” points an accusatory finger to Solomon's belief that money could buy anything, a belief rejected in the following verse and in 8:7c-d (“Baal-Hamon” in combination meaning “Baal of Wealth,” falsely claiming for this god wealth, the ability to grant wealth, or both).

8:14a Pass on: Cf. Jastrow (192^a); but possibly the meaning is “flee” (in this context, from the crowds that would detain him from time spent in private love with her).

Considering the Message (8:11-14)

No amount of wealth, the wife declaims, can deter her from loving her husband, and loving him freely. Jesus lived his earthly life as a poor man (Mat 8:20), but loved his people (Jn 13:1) freely (10:18). A wife who, though herself penniless, offers her love to her family (Tit 2:4) thus models herself on the lord of all (Ac 10:36).

The husband, for his part, is fully aware of what he has in his marriage; he does not take his wife's voice for granted. “He who finds a wife has found something good, and has obtained favor from Yahweh” (Pr 18:22).

The book ends not with a call to action, not a summary; it ends in motion, not at rest; it ends in with an eye on the future, not thoughts of the past. In this respect the close of Song of Songs is comparable to its opening: “The book starts in the middle of the lovers' story, which is never brought to an end” (Curtis, 120). The same is true for the love of God, for “in the coming ages” God will show “the immeasurable riches of his grace in kindness toward us in Christ Jesus” (Eph 2:7). Furthermore, just as the best love found between a husband and a wife is—as Song of Songs has shown repeatedly—in neither person passively inactive but passionately active, so the eternal future of God's beloved will not be one of endless boredom, but one of endless service (Rev 22:3²⁸).

More specifically, this is a call from an adoring wife who longs for her worthy husband's physical and emotional presence. As real as this call is in the best of marriages, how much more poignant is the call of the Church through the ages: “Amen! Yes, come, Lord Jesus!” (Rev 22:20).

Appendix 1: Who Composed the Song of Songs?

The first verse of the book has long been interpreted as identifying the author as “Solomon.”²⁹ Since (1) no further description of the author is given, (2) use of the name Solomon for individuals other than the king of Israel seems not to have been common—at least after that king's days were past—until long after biblical times,³⁰ and (3) King David's most famous son is known to have written many songs (1 Ki 4:32), SS 1:1, thus interpreted, almost certainly must refer to the Solomon whose story appears in the books of 1 Kings and 1 Chronicles.³¹ Identifying King Solomon as the author of the book, however, faces two obstacles.

²⁸ The verb λατρεύω, commonly translated “worship,” speaks neither of posture nor (primarily) of a worshipful state of mind, but instead active service to the divine being.

²⁹ In many languages, including English, there are traditional titles for all of the biblical books (“Genesis,” “Exodus,” etc.), but in most cases these titles are merely convenient labels, since in ancient Israel authors did not always provide titles for their books.

³⁰ Contrast the entry in Jastrow on this name (1587^a) with that on the name “Sim(e)on” (1600^a).

³¹ Arguably, traditional sequences of the Old Testament books imply an ancient assessment of Solomonic authorship; for example, in the oldest attest sequence, Song of Songs follows Proverbs and Ecclesiastes. This possibly solomonic triad, however, might be illusory; instead, there seems to be a large set of books (starting with Psalms and

First, there is a moral obstacle. Solomon eventually collected 700 wives and 300 concubines (1 Ki 11:3),³² raising significant doubts, to put it mildly, as to his moral qualifications to write a book about marital love. Yet when Solomon wrote this book, it was at the prompting of another author—the Holy Spirit (2 Pet 1:21). Furthermore, inspiration is ascribed to Scripture itself, not to writers (2 Tim 3:16). Thus, Solomon's imperfections do not negate the perfections of this book. Moreover, it might be precisely Solomon's regret that led him to set forth “a better way” (1 Cor 12:31b).³³ At any rate, what this book extols is the love every married couple should aim for, not the failure Solomon himself allowed himself to experience.

Second, there is a historical obstacle. Certain grammatical, and especially lexical, features of the book most likely reflect a stage of the Hebrew language that is post-exilic³⁴—that is to say, a stage of Hebrew that postdates Solomon's reign by several centuries! This is not, in itself, as fatal an objection to Solomonic authorship as it might at first sound, for there is much precedent in ancient Hebrew composition for linguistic modernization. For example, when the author of the book of Chronicles quotes from the earlier book of Kings,³⁵ he often paraphrases the text of Kings in a way that makes the wording of Kings more accessible to his contemporaries.³⁶ So perhaps what we have in the canonical Song of Songs is a work of Solomon which a later, anonymous, pen has touched up in order to speak more directly to a later generation of God's people. The original composition, on this model, has been lost. (A similar situation would come about in the English-language literary tradition if all copies of Shakespeare's works were lost to history except for the *No Fear Shakespeare* paraphrases.) That said, there are two difficulties with this approach: This model assumes a two-step composition process, and so injects complexity into the system; and some of the linguistic features of the book as we have it are hard to explain as stylistic updates, but are natural as elements intrinsic to the original composition.³⁷ Neither of these difficulties are insuperable, but they are difficulties nonetheless.

In light of these obstacles to Solomonic authorship, I wish to venture a bold hypothesis. I said above that 1:1 has long been interpreted as identifying the author as “Solomon,” but the Hebrew could also be understood as pointing to a woman named “Shalmah.”³⁸ (The writing system used in ancient Israel gave only partial indication of vowels, leaving the readers to insert them in their minds—ordinarily not too difficult for those fluent in Hebrew, but at times leading to ambiguities or difficulties.) This woman, we can reasonably hypothesize, wrote at a time when the linguistic features found in Song of Songs were more or less standard. Possibly she chose the era of King Solomon as a setting for her work because of the similarity of his name to hers. Similarly, she might playfully bookend the song with allusions to her name in 1:5 (with a place name that sounds like hers), in 7:1 (with a toponym, “Shulammite,” derived from the same root as “Shalmah”), and in 8:10 (with the Hebrew word שלום, “peace,” that derives from the same root as her name).³⁹ Obviously this is not a well-known individual,⁴⁰ but this is not much of an obstacle in that ancient Hebrew poetry, to judge

ending with Lamentations) arranged according to descend order of size (as measured by word count). In any case, inspiration does not seem to extend to the sequence of the books.

³² SS 6:8 evidently refers to a time when his mass-womanizing was a work in progress.

³³ I think I heard this approach from my uncle, Alan B. Brown.

³⁴ A comprehensive discussion is outside the scope of this commentary, but the most decisive example (many others could be cited) is פִּרְדָּס, a word that came into Hebrew not before the Achaemenid empire (Noonan, 181-182). Even if each individual seemingly post-Solomonic linguistic feature of the book could be shown to be open to other explanations, the cumulative effect of so many items would still place the burden of proof on those who would maintain Solomonic authorship.

³⁵ In Hebrew, 1-2 Kings and 1-2 Chronicles are each a single book; the division of both books into two parts is a later development.

³⁶ See Hurvitz *passim*. (Incidentally, this practice, it seems to me, goes a long way in justifying a fairly dynamic style of translation, as long as the sense of the underlying text is not manipulated, and inspiration is understood to reside in the original Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek of the Bible.)

³⁷ For example, in 4:13 the word פִּרְדָּס does not gloss some other word, nor is it clear why it would replace a word like גֶּן (which occurs eight times in the book) or even גִּבְעָה (which occurs in 6:11).

³⁸ Although the word “men” commonly occurs in English translations of 2 Pet 1:21, the Greek word there (ἀνθρώποι) means human beings, not males specifically (ἀνδρες or αρσενες).

³⁹ If Song of Songs is written in a northern dialect (so Rendsburg, 315-323), perhaps there is a linkage with another possible Syrian tradition (for another possible Syrian connection, cf. Appendix 4) of weaving one's name into one's work (see, for example, Brock and Kiraz, xv).

⁴⁰ The name is possibly attested at 7th century Lachish (Davies, 1:156) and in two unprovenanced bullae (2:77, 88).

from the biblical corpus, seems fairly often to have noted the author (something not true of ancient Hebrew prose); moreover, for various socio-economic reasons women are seldom named in either epigraphic or literary sources. There are some difficulties with this approach, perhaps the chief one being a reference to the Tirzah in 6:4, a city devastated by the Assyrians. But the pre-assyrian fame need not have faded altogether, especially given references to it in the biblical book of Kings, and the city's beauty is in Hebrew also all but embedded in the name itself (תרצה, from the root רצה).⁴¹

In closing, we should all bear in mind that, as mentioned above, whoever the author of Song of Songs might be, there is an author behind the author: The Holy Spirit, God himself. Questions over the human author are not irrelevant, but they pale in comparison to this fact.

Appendix 2: A Biblical Perspective on Sexual Intimacy

Many people down through the centuries have assumed that sex is either bad, or necessary (to bring children into the world, or to alleviate one's desires) but not commendable. There are probably two main causes for this feeling. First, there has long been a notion that physical things—especially things that bring pleasure—are sinful. Second, many associate sex with certain sinful activities. But what does the Bible say?

As to the first point, physical things are not necessarily bad. After all, in the first chapter of Genesis, God creates the physical universe, and in verse 31 He sees that it is “very good.” Furthermore, Jesus Christ came in a physical body (Col 2:9). Some spiritual beings (like the evil spirits that sometimes inhabit people) are not good, but evil! Our world is broken because of sin (Rom 8), but Jesus is coming back to renew the earth (Rev 21).

As to the second point, things such as fornication and adultery are sins, certainly, but that does not mean sex is. Physical things, including our physical bodies, can be used to bring God glory (1 Cor 6:20), or to sin (Rom 6). Consider money. Money can glorify God when given cheerfully (2 Cor 9:7) and sacrificially (2 Cor 8:2, Mk 12:44) without hypocrisy (Mat 6:1-4), but to love it is “a root of all kinds of evils” (1 Tim 6:10). It's how one uses money that counts. Sex is similar. Outside its rightful context or unaccompanied by genuine love, it is cheap and self-serving; within marriage and motivated by intense commitment, it is profound and beneficial. Sex can be beautiful: God designed it (Gen 2:18-25, with which compare 1 Cor 6:16) and promotes it (Prov 5:18-19, 1 Cor 7:5). The tone with which Scripture treats sexual activity within marriage is dignified but not stuffy, gentle but not hesitant.

All this said, it seems to me that Christianity in the United States has long overemphasized marriage. Christian parents and congregations have in many cases steered young people towards marriage so firmly that the possibility of a single life is barely considered; these pressures often continue into middle age and beyond. But Jesus instructs his followers that God's will for some is singleness (Mat 19:12),⁴² and such was his own practice, as well as Paul's (1 Cor 7:7). “Marriage, for all its blessings, is not intrinsic to being whole and fully realized as a person” (Allberry, 52). God's will for some is marriage, and his will for others is singleness; both are callings to be validated and valued.

Whether one is married or single, however, a right view of sex is important for (1) honoring the creator in his world, for (2) promoting human flourishing, and for (3) understanding more fully the profoundness of the Church.

1. Honoring the Creator and His World: God fashioned all the universe—not least humanity,

⁴¹ Another notable argument in favor of Solomonic authorship is that the book contains at least one reference to Egypt (1:9), and arguably various allusions to Egyptian literature. However, in the early post-exilic period Egyptian material culture was very popular in the Levant, Persian political dominance notwithstanding (Steiner and Killebrew, 85); it is reasonable to speculate that Egyptian literature was also a point of interest then as well.

⁴² Eunuchs in the ancient world were men whose anatomy was mutilated in such a way as to make it impossible for them to impregnate a woman. (Usually this was done for men who would be working closely with wives or concubines of the king in order to minimize the risk of a royal step-child who might one day challenge the authority of the king or of his preferred successor. The practice is a testament to the lengths many in our sin-ridden world will go in order to retain power.) The term could also refer to men who filled the same or similar governmental positions as these men but were not so mutilated. This more figurative sense of the term is probably what paves the way for Jesus to speak of those who “make themselves eunuchs”: Since the Bible does not favor mutilation of one's body (Col 2:23), Jesus is surely not speaking literally here, but rather using dramatic language to speak of those who out of a considered and abiding dedication to the things of God, commit themselves to a life without sex, i.e. a life of singleness.

including human anatomy, physiology, and psychology. People must honor the fact that God chose to create two genders, male and female. God supplies each human individual the essential characteristics of one gender or the other.⁴³ He has also ordained in his word that sex as a specific sort of interaction between a male and a female (not between two males, between two females, or some other option; cf. Rom 1:26-27) is to be confined to marriage (Pr 5:1-23, Heb 13:4).

2. *Promoting Human Flourishing*: All of God's creative work is good (Gen 1:31) and wisely done (Ps 104:24). Therefore, we can rightly infer that God correctly chose our gender, and that—while there are unbiblical stereotypes and expectations concerning our gender which we can discount—our life will be most fulfilling when we live in ways that reflect characteristics distinctive of our gender, and less fulfilling when we try to mimic patterns tied to the other gender. Avoiding certain homosexual behaviors and maintaining fidelity to a single sexual partner will go a long way toward avoiding harmful, or even fatal, consequences (cf. Rom 1:27; Eph 5:5). By the same token, following God's prescriptions for one's own sexuality opens the door for great benefits: Those called to singleness who continue in that path benefit from the joys of an undistracted devotion to the things of eternity (1 Cor 7:35); those who are married can benefit from an emotionally secure relationship, potentially enjoy a vibrant and exciting sex life (as can be seen throughout Song of Songs), and, God willing, the blessing of children (Ps 127:3).

3. *Understanding More Fully the Profoundness of the Church*: When a wife and her husband are by common consent naked together, they briefly return, so to speak, to pre-sin Eden, when the absence of sin made clothing unnecessary (Gen 2:25).⁴⁴ There they catch a glimpse of post-sin Earth, when the curse of sin will have been taken away forever (Rev 21:3-4).⁴⁵ When a husband and his wife have sex, their physical union sounds an echo of the spiritual union between Christ and Church (Eph 5:31-32).⁴⁶ More broadly, the excited romance of a godly marriage (Pr 5:18-19, Song of Songs *passim*) portrays the unending joy Christ and his Church do and will enjoy in each other (1 Pet 1:8, Rev 21:3).

Appendix 3: Words for “Virgin” in the Hebrew Old Testament

Over the past century or so, tremendous controversy has erupted over the proper translation of two words often translated into English as “virgin.” Although only the second (in alphabetical order) of these two words occurs in the Song of Songs, discussing the one begs for mention of the other, so this appendix will briefly address both words in term.

The first word to consider is בתולה. The cognates of בתולה in related languages show ambiguity as to whether specifically “virgin” or generally “young woman” is meant (see e.g., Gordon, 377^b-378^a). It does seem that over time the Aramaic cognate came to mean “virgin,” and this development either influenced, or was on a parallel track with, developments within the Hebrew language (cf. Jastrow, 200^b). But (with the possible exception of very late books) earlier rather than later Hebrew usage is what should predominate in the discussion. Brown, Driver, & Briggs define the word as “virgin,” and point to a number of passages showing a בתולה as “one living apart in her father’s house *as a virgin*” (143^b, italics original), e.g., Gen 24:16,⁴⁷ Jdg 19:24, and 2 Sam 13:2. Koehler & Baumgartner agree in the meaning “virgin,” though regarding Joel

⁴³ All creation groans with the rippling waves of sin's effects (Rom 8:22), and so in this as in every area of life there is difficulty: In rare cases, persons are born with birth defects that make gender identification difficult, and in more frequent cases, same-sex attraction is experienced. The former difficulty, however, does not obscure a person's eternal identity any more than present muteness will inhibit eternal songs of praise to God; on the latter difficulty, see the helpful pointers in Allberry (36-37, 43-59).

⁴⁴ The abundance of garden-related imagery in the book might not be coincidental.

⁴⁵ This is probably why in the next life marriage will be a thing of the past (Mk 12:25)—the open communion between God and his people pictured by marriage will be a reality, so marriage, a picture of that reality before its coming, will no longer be necessary.

⁴⁶ Eph 5:22-33 refers to sexual activity at most obliquely and partially, but Paul's logic in the rebuke 1 Cor 6:16 (which cites Gen 2:24) establishes that the physical union of vagina and penis does, or ought to, symbolize the spiritual bond between a man and woman. In a sense, sex is a picture of marriage, even as marriage is a picture of ecclesiology.

⁴⁷ In this verse the word בתולה is immediately followed by the qualification ואיש לא ידעה, “and she had not known a man” (on the pointing in SRHB cf. Jdg 11:39, 21:12, Lk 1:34, and Taw 2017l, 138b; 1 Ki 1:4 is obviously different). Is this phrase here to remove the ambiguity of בתולה, or does it emphasize the meaning of that term by saying the same thing another way? A comparable phrase occurs with the ambiguous phrase “two daughters” in 19:8, but this parallel does not necessarily clear things up, since the fact that the daughters live with their father

1:8 they query, “[does this mean that the woman had been] married at a young age?” (1: 167^a). By contrast, Clines defines the word “a young, marriageable (rarely, married, as J1 1_g) woman, sometimes with specific ref[erence] to virginity” (141^b). This last definition seems to me to fit the data best. At times, the word does clearly mean “virgin,” as in Ex 22:16 (Hebrew, 15) (for according to Lev 20:10 the penalty for consensual sex with a woman married to someone else would not be a fee, as here, but death) and Dt 22:19 (see the preceding context). As just alluded to, Joel 1:8 seems to picture a young woman whose husband has died;⁴⁸ while Isa 47:1 describes Babylon as a בתולה, even though in vv8-9 she is described as married-with-children; and Lam 1:15 calls Judah a בתולה, even though she is charged in the chapter with having had multiple lovers (vv2, 19), and is pictured as having children (v16). The word always means “young woman,” generally (if not always) with an emphasis on youthful beauty and/or tenderness, often (not always) implying a virginal status.⁴⁹

The second word often translated “virgin” is עלמה. The related languages shed even less light than they do on בתולה. Brown, Driver, & Briggs (761^b) define עלמה as “young woman (ripe sexually; maid or newly married).” Similarly Koehler and Baumgartner have “marriageable girl,” “a girl who is able to be married,” or “young woman” (1: 836^a). Clines has “young woman, girl, per[haps] specif[ically] uninitiated, unknowing female, or per[haps] specif[ically] court lady” (620^a). Jastrow defines it a “vigorous” young lady (1085a with 1084b). The word occurs only a handful of times in the OT, so all instances can be cited. A young woman of marriageable age—and, culturally speaking, probably a virgin also—is what Abraham’s servant prays to find for Isaac in Gen 24:43. A young Miriam gets Moses’ mother to come wean him (Ex 2:8); “the way of a man with an עלמה” is noted as a mysterious phenomenon, difficult to trace, in Pr 30:19; and עלמות sing in Ps 68:25 in some public celebration (the psalm is famously obscure), think highly of the husband (or husband-to-be) in the Song of Songs (1:3). The controversy centers above all on Isa 7:14. For the sake of completeness, the form עלמות appears as a musical term in 1 Chr 15:20 and Ps 46:superscription (Hebrew 1); and—depending on how one resolves certain questions of text and of vocalization—potentially also in Ps 9:superscription (Hebrew 1) and 48:14 (Hebrew 15). This notation is often thought to mean that the song in question is meant for soprano voices, but in 1 Chr 15:19 at least some of the singers are male, which does not rule out high voices but does cast the theory somewhat into question in my mind. Perhaps it indicates a certain key, or perhaps it is the name of some now-unknown tune that began with the word עלמות. The male equivalent (עלם) occurs in 1 Sam 17:56 and in 20:22 (and, according to some witnesses, v38 as well). These passages refer to unmarried men (though not quite certainly in the second and third cases), but the emphasis in all three cases is clearly on their youth. A related noun, עלום (always plural), occurs in Job 20:11, 33:25, Ps 89:45 (Hebrew 46), and Isa 54:4; the meaning is “youth,” not “virginity,” is at least the first three passages, and arguably the last as well. It appears, then, that עלמה denotes virtually the same thing as בתולה, that is, a young woman of marriageable age, but quite possibly a virgin; but whereas בתולה has connotations of youthful attractiveness, עלמה has connotations of youthful strength. What, then, of Isa 7:14? There some ancient Greek translations render the term with νεανία (a general Greek term for “young woman”), but the oldest known Greek translation, together with the NT (Mat 1:21), renders עלמה with παρθενος, virtually equivalent to English “virgin” (except that, especially in earlier Greek literature, it has a little more room than the English “virgin” for the more general idea of “young woman”). Without delving too deeply into what is, again, an extremely contentious topic, I would suggest that the flexibility inherent in עלמה allows for the possibility that Isaiah had a son by his wife whose name bespoke God’s omnipresent care for his people and whose youth saw the fall of the Syrian state that Ahaz so feared (cf. vv15-17); but also for the possibility that far beyond the immediate perils of Isaiah’s day, our Lord Jesus Christ, in every sense God Among Us, would be born not just a young woman, but even a virgin, bringing about, as every other case, a fuller, truer fulfilment to the words of the prophets than any could have dared to dream.

implies virginal status. It is difficult to resolve this question.

⁴⁸ Some, however, take the scenario here to be a woman betrothed to a man who died before they came together.

⁴⁹ The related noun בתול (always in the plural) is widely taken to mean “virginity,” “proof of virginity,” and it certainly means this in Lev 21:13 and Dt 22:15, 17. But Jdg 11:37-38 is debatable (is she lamenting the loss of her virginity, or of her young life?), as it seems to me, Eze 23:3 and 8 (does not the reference in that passage to repeated and illicit sexual activity on her part suggest that her youthful bodily form is meant [so Clines, 141^b]?). In any case, it is widely recognized in linguistics that a word with a shared root (בתול as compared to בתולה, in this case) does not necessarily reflect all denotations and connotations of the morphologically related word.

Appendix 4: Royal Terms in Song of Songs

Many interpretive questions have long vexed readers of Song of Songs. One of them concerns the various times (apart from where Solomon is referred to, viz. 3:9, 3:11) where the male protagonist is referred to as “king” (1:4, v12, 7:6⁵⁰); similarly, the female protagonist is referred to as “princess” (7:2; see “Notes on Some Details” there for further options). One approach to these labels is to take them literally, but taking the male protagonist as royalty runs into serious problems (see Introduction, Part 4), and one wonders why a princess would be working the vineyard until her skin was thoroughly tanned (1:5-6).

Another approach is to appeal to a Syrian custom: “It is held in some quarters that the marriage customs of modern Syria (which may go back to ancient times) afford a clue to the nature and purpose of the book. The festal season lasts for a week, and during that time the bride and bridegroom are hailed and treated as king and queen. Their throne is the threshing-sledge, a heavy structure of wooden boards forming a small platform, studded with nails and stones on its under side... A seat is placed on it for the wedding ceremony, and the young couple are drawn in state wherever they have to go.... It is at least possible that similar procedure was current in ancient Palestine, though direct evidence is lacking” (Robinson, 198). This is an interesting theory, and there are possible or probable connections between Song of Songs and northern Israel (which, of course, borders southern Syria). Yet the gap in time between modern Syria and the writing of Song of Songs is enormous, and the cultures concerned are far from identical.⁵¹

The interpretation which seems most in keeping with the spirit and style of Song of Songs is to take these royal terms as metaphorical. The husband is not a political king, but the wife finds his presence as impressive as that of a monarch; the wife is not literally royal, but in her husband’s eyes she glitters as much as any queen’s ballroom gown.

Appendix 5: The Text and Translation of Song of Songs 1:4e

There is probably a difference of reading concerning מִיִּשְׂרָיִם אֲהַבְךָ (“rightly do they love you”) in 1:4. Dirksen (57*) takes the Old Greek (εὐθὺς ἠγάπησεν σε) to be interpretive, but while it would not be unusual for an Old Greek translator to render a Hebrew plural noun as a singular (particularly one like מִיִּשְׂרָיִם; cf. 1 Chron 29:17, etc.), it would be unusual for him or her to render a plural verb as though it was singular (especially in a notably literal translation like the present one). It seems plausible, then, to understand a *Vorlage* אֲהַבְךָ מִיִּשְׂרָיִם as lying behind the Old Greek (granting that such was not fully understood).

Such a *Vorlage* would solve at least one difficulty that would seem to be inherent in the Masoretic Text.⁵² On the one hand, if it is the Daughters of Jerusalem who are speaking, the identity of the implied subject of the verb (“they”) is unclear. There are in Song of Songs two passing references to the husband’s friends (1:7, 8:13), but if they were the ones doing the loving (and such is unlikely, since both the verses just mentioned implicitly decline rather than invite the participation of those individuals), it seems to me that some masculine counterpart to the עַלְמוֹת of v3 would appear. On the other hand, if it is not the Daughters of Jerusalem who are speaking,⁵³ we are left with an orphaned line of poetry.⁵⁴ The reading implied by the Old Greek,⁵⁵ by contrast, provides a third, climactic element to the parallelism which begins in v4a: The wife is a

⁵⁰ Cf. also 6:12b and “Notes on Some Details” there.

⁵¹ Perhaps the Syrian practice is one that evolved out of a somewhat different cultural practice shared in ancient times by (at least) southern Syria and northern Israel.

⁵² The Peshitta rendering (ܡܝܫܪܝܡ) might be the translator’s attempt (it is hard to imagine how a Hebrew *Vorlage* אֲהַבְךָ could have arisen) to paraphrase in the light of a difficult line. (The 6QCant reading מִיִּשְׂרָיִם אֲהַבְךָ is, I suspect, merely a copyist error, since *waw* and *yodh* on the one hand and *kaph* and *mem* on the other were quite similar in some ancient scripts.)

⁵³ If it is not the Daughters of Jerusalem, then presumably the wife is speaking.

⁵⁴ Recall, as mentioned in the Introduction, that among the chief characteristics of Hebrew poetry, including the poetry found in Song of Songs, is parallelism, the grouping of two or three closely related lines of text. (Certainly the line under discussion is not parallel to v5a, which line, in tandem with v5b, begins a different train of thought with a different tone.)

⁵⁵ Note also that I deviate from the traditional vowel marking of דִּיד so as to indicate that the wife, not the husband, is spoken of. (Such vowel markings as the one in question here do not go back to the original text, so they can be altered where there is exegetical warrant.)

woman whose peers admire her, a woman whose love evokes their admiration, and a woman who is a fitting object of her husband's love.⁵⁶ This line of thought prepares the way for the pivot of v5, where the wife, on hearing that she is a fitting object of her husband's love, gives voice to her sense of insecurity. In short, the Old Greek reading is more coherent than is the masoretic reading.

An explanation for the origin of the masoretic reading is not far to seek: At the end of v3 the form אֶהְיוֹן appears, and an early scribe, having recently written that form, could easily have subconsciously substituted the same form for אֶהְיֶה.⁵⁷

Appendix 6: On 4:1-5:1 Probably *Not* Being the Wedding Night

Preachers and commentators often refer to 4:1-5:1 as the two protagonists' wedding night. There are at least five basic points that can be made in favor of this view, but I find each of them faulty. First, there is the sexual nature of what it said, particularly near the end of the pericope. The pericope is indeed sexual to a degree, but it does not follow from this fact that this pericope is covering the wedding night specifically, for the poet appears to refer to sexual activity at several prior points in the book—it would seem rather that the couple is depicted as already married from 1:1 on. Second, 4:1-5:1 follows on the heels of 3:7-11, which is undeniably a wedding procession (3:11c). As argued under the “Notes on Some Details” portion of the commentary to 3:6-11, however, there is a good case to be made that the man referred to there is not the male protagonist of the poem but a literary foil, King Solomon. Third, 4:1d mentions a veil, which item—given widespread practice today and possibly ancient practice as well⁵⁸—might suggest that the wedding had occurred earlier that same day. Yet mention of a veil does not require a recent wedding, for veils, while by no means universally worn by women in biblical times,⁵⁹ served a variety of purposes (at least the following: prostitution, Gen 38:14; ornamentation, Isa 3:23; and magic, Eze 13:18); and a reference to a veil occurs again in this book (6:7b), so unless Song of Songs contains multiple retellings of the wedding night, the veil in 4:1d need not imply that 4:1-5:1 speaks of the wedding night. Fourth, the man uses the term “bride” in 4:8a (and several times in the following verses). But lexicographers widely acknowledge that this Hebrew word (כלה) can (like the English word “bride”) also refer to a woman *after* the wedding ceremony (see further “Notes on Some Details” to 4:8a). Fifth, 4:12 could be speaking of her virginity up to that point, but it could just as easily be speaking of her fidelity to her husband up to that point and beyond.

In short, I do not think that 4:1-5:1 describes the couple's wedding night. What's more, I wonder whether referring to the passage in such terms unnecessarily promotes embarrassment in readers and listeners, and might even build up a conceptual context in which some will entertain lustful thoughts in their minds. To be sure, such has not necessarily been the intent of the many believing pastors and teachers who have referred to a wedding night here. But those exegeting Song of Songs must avoid giving the impression that the book is verbal pornography. This would be a fatally mistaken impression.⁶⁰ Sexual enjoyment by the wife and husband of each other is a prominent theme in this book, but it is never painted with such a vivid

⁵⁶ This is climactic in that, since the interest of Song of Songs is largely romantic, the wife's husband's assessment of her is of greater significance than is the assessment of her peers.

⁵⁷ An alternative or complementary potential mechanism is errant dittography of the final *kaph*, given the visual similarity of that letter to *waw*. Unintentional explanations of this sort are in my view preferable in general to speculative appeals to deliberate scribal intervention.

⁵⁸ The latter point is not quite certain. Rebekah veils herself in Gen 24:65, and this action might well have been motivated by the expectation of a wedding that day (cf. v67, though it is not certain whether that verse refers to the same or a later date; contemporary standards of hospitality to a traveler, as well as the elaborate wedding ceremonies of the time, might make a period of rest and recovery for her after her journey a reasonable inference), but it could also have been motivated out of a desire to see that Isaac's assent to the marriage stemmed from his hearing of the events that led to it (cf. v66) rather than merely her own beauty (v16). Jacob's surprise at having married Leah (29:25) might have been due to a veil, but a swap of one sister for another in the dark (v23) perhaps explains the success of the ruse.

⁵⁹ Several unveiled Israelite women appear in the Black Obelisk of Shalmaneser III. Such might also be the implication of Gen 38:19 (though perhaps Tamar substituted a prostitute's veil for a widow's).

⁶⁰ While there is reference to kissing (1:2a), there is no detailed narration of intimate events (the closest the book comes in probably 7:7-8, but even this passage remains in the realm of metaphor). Neither the husband nor the wife is anywhere in the poem depicted as naked—there are enough references to clothing to rule out such an interpretation. (4:5a is not an exception; see “Notes on Some Details” there.)

brush that children or teenagers should be shielded from it.⁶¹ Indeed, someone reading Song of Songs itself (reading commentaries on the book can be another matter) learns nothing about anatomy or the specifics of sex that he or she did not already know by other means. The book celebrates sex, not as Hollywood would,⁶² but with images of gardens and aromas, of plants and mountains; and not in the manner of red-cheeked cop-outs (“the birds and the bees”) but in the manner of soul-stirring music. The Scriptures speak of sex with prudence but not prudery, with respect but not fear. Even if everyone on earth speaks of sex improperly—whether with misplaced shame or with untoward hubris—God will be justified in his words (cf. Rom 3:4).

Appendix 7: Text and Translation in 8:6e

Some translations contain in SS 8:6 a reference to Yahweh (e.g., the ESV has “Its flashes are flames of fire, the very flame of the LORD”). This approach would seem to demand reading *שלהבת יה* at the end of the verse, but the external evidence for this division of the letters is weak: While a good number of Hebrew manuscripts read thus, these manuscripts tend to be reflective of the Western school and of the ben Naphtali tradition (Ginsburg, 1537), which in my view are less reliable than the Eastern school and the ben Asher tradition. Important Hebrew manuscripts and editions support the one-word reading, as do the Old Greek, Peshitta, and Vulgate versions. (The Targum is difficult to assess, given its extreme translation style.)

This established, the question of meaning comes into focus. Some have suggested a noun based on *שלהבת* with an intensive *ya* affirmative. An affirmative with the required sense seems not to exist, however (cf. Lipiński, 229-231). Instead, the word is simply the noun *שלהבת* with a third person feminine singular suffix (the referent being *קנאה* or possibly *אהבה*).⁶³ On this account, *רשפיה* is topic-fronting (see the translation).

It seems, then, that God is mentioned directly nowhere in this book. (At most he is mentioned indirectly—see on 2:7b under “Notes on Some Details.”) This is the case in Esther, though it is not clear whether the reasons for this absence are the same. In the case of the Song of Songs, three possibilities present themselves to my mind: (1) It could be that notable absence is meant to highlight something about God, namely that his providence remains active even where his presence remains unseen; (2) it could be that in the era in which the poet wrote, a strong cultural sensitivity toward abusing the name of God led to reluctance to refer to him directly; or (3) perhaps direct reference to God simply did not come up, given the subject matter and limited scope of the poem (it is not a theology of marriage or an ethical guide, but a celebration of wedded romance). (In any case, it can be noted that God's name is *not* some talisman the mere use of which brings divine blessing.) The first option seems to me to read too much into the matter. The second option is also somewhat speculative, but hard for me to dismiss altogether. To my mind the third option most probably describes the author's intent. But it is true that God's decrees, character, and intervention do not form one component among others of a successful marriage, but rather empower and give meaning to every aspect of what is good in a marriage.

Appendix 8: Song of Songs in English

1:1 *Song of Songs*, which is Shalmah's.

[Wife:]

1:2a May he kiss me with the kisses of his mouth!

1:2b For your love is better than wine,

1:3a Better than the fragrance of oils.

1:3b Oil when it is being purified is your name—

1:3c For that reason the young women love you.

1:4a Draw me after you! Let us run!

⁶¹ Modern scholarship has made numerous suggestions of certain words or passages in the book that could refer to highly sexual matters, but suffice it to say here that in my view few of these suggestions are particularly probable.

⁶² It is surely not by accident that God chose the medium of writing for sacred Scripture (art, including art that narrates events and art accompanied by text, did exist in ancient times, so there were alternatives). For instance, 2 Sam 11:2 retells a historical fact in a manner that, due to its lack of specificity, need occasion no stumbling, while the same event could not be retold responsibly with images.

⁶³ This approach entails vocalizing the word differently than the medieval Hebrew manuscripts (but in agreement with the vocalization assumed by the translator of the Old Greek version).

1:4b Let the king bring me into his bedroom!

[Daughters of Jerusalem, to the wife:]

1:4c We will be glad and rejoice in you;

1:4d We will proclaim your love as better than wine.

1:4e Rightly does he love you.

[Wife:]

1:5a I am dark[-skinned], but lovely, Daughters of Jerusalem,

1:5b Like the tents of Kedar, like the curtains of Shalmah.

1:6a Do not stare at me on account of my dark complexion,

1:6b On account of how the sun has darkened me,

1:6c [For] my brothers were kindled against me;

1:6d They gave me the job of keeping up the vineyard;

1:6e [As a result] my own vineyard I did not keep up.

1:7a Tell me, you whom my soul loves,

1:7b Where do you shepherd [your flock]? Where do you settle them down in the afternoon [heat]?

1:7c For why should I be like a prostitute among the flocks of your companions?

[Husband:]

1:8a You do know, most beautiful among women—

1:8b Go out in the tracks of the flock,

1:8c And shepherd your goats in the shepherds' resting places.

[Husband:]

1:9a To a mare among the chariot [horses] of Pharaoh,

1:9b I compare you, my friend.

1:10a Lovely are your cheeks with *torim*,

1:10b Your neck with a *kharuz* necklace.

[Daughters of Jerusalem, to the wife:]

1:11a Golden *torim* we will make for you,

1:11b With silver beads.

[Wife:]

1:12a While the king was [reclining] on his *mesabh*,

1:12b He became entranced with [the fragrance of] my nard.

1:13a A sachet of myrrh is my beloved to me,

1:13b Spending the night between my breasts.

1:14a A cluster of henna flowers is my beloved to me,

1:14b In the vineyards of Engedi.

[Husband:]

1:15a Oh, how beautiful you are, my friend!

1:15b Oh, how beautiful you are! Your eyes are doves.

[Wife:]

1:16a Oh, how handsome you are, my beloved!

1:16b You are so charming! And our bed is verdant!

1:17a The beams of our house are cedars;

1:17b Our rafters are junipers.

2:1a I am an asphodel of the Sharon,

2:1b A water lotus of the valleys.

[Husband:]

2:2a Like a water lotus among the thorn bushes,

2:2b So is my friend among women.

[Wife:]

2:3a Like an apple tree among the trees of the forest,

2:3b So is my beloved among men;

2:3c In its shade I delightedly sat down,

2:3d And its fruit was sweet to my taste.

2:4a He brought me in to the house of wine,
2:4b And his banner over me was love.
2:5a Sustain me with raisin cakes;
2:5b Renew my strength with apples!
2:5c For I am lovesick.
2:6a Let his left hand be under my head,
2:6b And his right hand embrace me!
2:7a I adjure you, Daughters of Jerusalem,
2:7b By the gazelles, or by does of the field,
2:7c Not to stir up or awaken love
2:7d Until it pleases.
2:8a [I hear] the sound of my beloved!
2:8b Look, he is coming,
2:8c Skipping on the mountains,
2:8d [And] leaping on the hills.
2:9a My beloved is like a gazelle,
2:9b Or the young [and strong] offspring of the deer,
2:9c Look, [now] he is standing at the house,
2:9d Peering through the windows,
2:9e Gazing through the lattice.
2:10a My beloved said to me,
2:10b "Rise up, my friend,
2:10c "My beautiful one, and come along!
2:11a "For look—the winter is past,
2:11b "And the rain[y season] has gone on its way.
2:12a "The blossoms are appearing in the land,
2:12b "The time of pruning has drawn near,
2:12c "And the voice of the turtle-dove is heard in our land.
2:13a "The fig tree is forming young fruit,
2:13b "And the young fruit has given forth its fragrance.
2:13c "Oh, arise, my friend, my beautiful one, and come!
2:14a "A dove in the clefts of the rock,
2:14b "In the hiding place of the steep slope,
2:14c "Show me your appearance,
2:14d "[And] let me hear your voice,
2:14e "For your voice is sweet,
2:14f "And your form is lovely."
2:15a Catch the foxes for us,
2:15b The little foxes that spoil the vineyards,
2:15c For our vineyard is blossoming.
2:16a My beloved is mine,
2:16b And I am his—
2:16c He who shepherds among the asphodels.
2:17a Until the wind dissipates,
2:17b And the shadows flee,
2:17c Oh, come, my beloved, and be like a gazelle,
2:17d Or like the young [and strong] offspring of the deer
2:17e On the rugged mountains.
3:1a On my bed at night I searched
3:1b For the one my soul loves.
3:1c I searched for him but did not find him.
3:2a [I thought,] "I will arise and go around
3:2b "The city, the squares, and the plazas;

3:2c "I will seek the one my soul loves."
3:2d I searched for him but did not find him.
3:3a The sentries who go around the city found me.
3:3b [I asked them,] "Have you seen the one my soul loves?"
3:4a I had barely moved on from them
3:4b When I found the one my soul loves.
3:4c I held him and did not let go
3:4d Until I had brought him to the house of my mother,
3:4e And to the room of the one who conceived me.
3:5a I adjure you, Daughters of Jerusalem,
3:5b By the gazelles, or by does of the field,
3:5c Not to stir up or awaken love
3:5d Until it pleases.
[Daughters of Jerusalem, concerning the wife:]
3:6a Who is this coming from the desert,
3:6b Like a column of dust, scented with myrrh and frankincense,
3:6c [Scented] better than any aromatic a merchant could offer?
[Wife:]
3:7a Take a look—it's the litter of Solomon!
3:7b Sixty warriors surround it
3:7c From the warriors of Israel.
3:8a All of them are grasping a sword, trained in war,
3:8b Each man with his sword on his thigh, [guarding] against the terror of the night.
3:9a Solomon the king has made a litter for himself
3:9b From the wood of Lebanon.
3:10a Its pillars he made with silver;
3:10b Its supports with gold.
3:10c His chariot is purple;
3:10d Its interior covered with leather
3:10e From the Daughters of Jerusalem.
3:11a Go out and look, daughters of Zion, on King Solomon,
3:11b With the crown with which his mother crowned him
3:11c On the day of his marriage, and his day of gladness of heart.
[Husband:]
4:1a Oh, you are beautiful, my friend;
4:1b Oh, you are beautiful!
4:1c Your eyes are doves
4:1d Behind your veil.
4:1e Your hair is like a flock of goats
4:1f That playfully make their way down [the slopes of] Mount Gilead.
4:2a Your teeth are like a shorn flock
4:2b That comes away from washing,
4:2c For all of them are twins,
4:2d And none is bereaved [of its partner].
4:3a Like a scarlet cord are your lips,
4:3b And your mouth is lovely;
4:3c Like a slice of pomegranate
4:3d Is your forehead behind your veil.
4:4a Like the tower of David is your neck,
4:4b Built in courses.
4:4c A thousand in number are the shields hung upon it;
4:4d [A thousand in number are] all the javelins of the warriors.
4:5a Your two breasts are like two fawns,

4:5b Twins of a gazelle,
 4:5c Grazing among the asphodels.
 4:6a Until the wind dissipates,
 4:6b And the shadows flee,
 4:6c I will gladly go to the mountain of myrrh,
 4:6d And to the hill of frankincense.
 4:7a You are wholly beautiful, my friend,
 4:7b And there is no blemish in you.
 4:8a [Come] with me from Lebanon, O bride!
 4:8b Come with me from Lebanon!
 4:8c Journey [with me] from Mount Amanah,
 4:8d From Mount Senir and [from Mount] Hermon,
 4:8e From the dwellings of lions,
 4:8f From the mountains of leopards.
 4:9a You have stolen my heart, my sister, O bride!
 4:9b You have stolen my heart with one glance of your eyes,
 4:9c With one link of your chain necklace.
 4:10a How powerful is your love, my sister, O bride!
 4:10b How much better is your love than wine,
 4:10c And the fragrance of your oils than any spices.
 4:11a Like dripping honey are your lips, O bride.
 4:11b Fig cakes and milk are under your tongue,
 4:11c And the aroma of your garments is like the aroma of Lebanon.
 4:12a A locked garden is my sister, O bride—
 4:12b A locked garden, a sealed spring.
 4:13a Your shoots are a garden of pomegranates,
 4:13b With the finest fruit,
 4:13c [And with] henna plants and nard,
 4:14a Nard and saffron, a spice reed and cinnamon,
 4:14b With all the trees of Lebanon,
 4:14c Myrrh and aloe
 4:14d With all the best balsam.
 4:15a A spring of the gardens [are you],
 4:15b A well with water that is free-flowing
 4:15c And that rushes down from Lebanon [itself].
 [Wife:]
 4:16a Awake, O north wind,
 4:16b And come, O south wind—
 4:16c Breathe on my garden,
 4:16d That its balsam may flow;
 4:16e Let my beloved come to his garden,
 4:16f And eat of its best fruits.
 [Husband:]
 5:1a I come to my garden, my sister, O bride;
 5:1b I collect my myrrh with my balsam;
 5:1c I eat my honeycomb with my fig cakes;
 5:1d I drink my wine with my milk.
 [Daughters of Jerusalem:]
 5:1e Eat, friends;
 5:1f Drink and enjoy, lovers!
 [Wife:]
 5:2a I was sleeping, but my mind was awake.
 5:2b The sound of my beloved knocking [at the door].

5:2c [He said,] "Open for me, my sister,
 5:2d "My friend, my dove, my perfect one!
 5:2e "For my head is full of dew,
 5:2f "[And] my locks [are full] of [water] droplets."
 5:3a I have [already] taken off my dress—
 5:3b How can I put it on [again]?
 5:3c I have [already] washed my feet—
 5:3d How can I dirty them [again]?
 5:4a My beloved withdrew his hand from the hole,
 5:4b And my feelings were stirred for him.
 5:5a I arose to open [the door] for my beloved,
 5:5b And my hands dripped with myrrh,
 5:5c And my hands [dripped] with flowing myrrh
 5:5d On the handles of the [door's] lock.
 5:6a I opened for my beloved,
 5:6b But my beloved had gone out of sight.
 5:6c My soul had gone out with his words;
 5:6d [Yet] I searched for him but did not find him,
 5:6e [And] I called to him but he did not answer me.
 5:7a The sentries who go around the city found me;
 5:7b They hit me; they struck me; the wall-sentries pulled my shawl off.
 5:8a I adjure you, Daughters of Jerusalem,
 5:8b If you find my beloved,
 5:8c Tell him that I am lovesick.
 [Daughters of Jerusalem, to the wife:]
 5:9a What makes your beloved so special,
 5:9b Most beautiful among women?
 5:9c What makes your beloved so special,
 5:9d That thus you adjure us?
 [Wife:]
 5:10a My beloved is bright and ruddy,
 5:10b Outshining a myriad.
 5:11a His head is pure gold;
 5:11b His hair is wavy,
 5:11c Black like a raven.
 5:12a His eyes are like doves
 5:12b On streams of water,
 5:12c Bathing in the foaming water,
 5:12d [And] sitting on a rim.
 5:13a His cheeks are like a bed of balsam,
 5:13b [A garden fruitfully] growing herbs.
 5:13c His lips are like asphodels, dripping with flowing myrrh.
 5:14a His arms are like golden rods,
 5:14b Set with topaz.
 5:14c His abdomen is an ivory bar,
 5:14d Covered with lapis lazuli.
 5:15a His thighs are columns of alabaster,
 5:15b Set on pedestals of pure gold.
 5:15c His appearance is like Lebanon,
 5:15d As excellent as the cedars [of Lebanon].
 5:16a His taste is altogether sweet,
 5:16b And his whole person is altogether desirable.
 5:16c This is my beloved,

5:16d And this is my friend,
 5:16e O Daughters of Jerusalem.
 [Daughters of Jerusalem, to wife:]
 6:1a Where has your beloved gone, most beautiful among women?
 6:1b Where has your beloved gone, that we may seek him with you?
 [Wife, to the Daughters of Jerusalem:]
 6:2a My beloved has gone to his garden;
 6:2b [My beloved has gone] to his balsam beds,
 6:2c To cultivate the garden,
 6:2d And to gather asphodels.
 6:3a I am my beloved's,
 6:3b And my beloved is mine—
 6:3c [My beloved] who shepherds among the asphodels.
 [Husband, to wife:]
 6:4a You are as beautiful, my friend, as Tirzah,
 6:4b As lovely as Jerusalem, awe-inspiring as an army with banners unfurled.
 6:5a Turn your gaze from me,
 6:5b For it has overwhelmed me.
 6:5c Your hair is like a flock of goats
 6:5d That playfully make their way down [the slopes of] Mount Gilead.
 6:6a Your teeth are like a flock of ewe-lambs
 6:6b That comes away from washing,
 6:6c For all of them are twins,
 6:6d And none is bereaved [of its partner].
 6:7a Like a slice of pomegranate
 6:7b Is your forehead behind your veil.
 6:8a There are sixty queens,
 6:8b And eighty concubines,
 6:8c And young women without number.
 6:9a My dove, my perfect one, is one!
 6:9b [Also] to her mother she is one;
 6:9c Pure to her who gave her birth.
 6:9d Women have seen her and count her blessed;
 6:9e Queens and concubines [have seen her], and praised her.
 [Daughters of Jerusalem, concerning the wife:]
 6:10a Who is this who looks down [at the earth below] like Dawn,
 6:10b As beautiful as Lebanon, as bright as the sun,
 6:10c Awe-inspiring as an army with banners unfurled?
 [Husband:]
 6:11a I went down to the walnut orchard,
 6:11b To examine the shoots of the wadi,
 6:11c [And] to see whether the vine had sprouted,
 6:11d And [whether] the pomegranate has bloomed.
 6:12a Before I knew it,
 6:12b She had set me among the [very] chariots of Amminadab.
 [Daughters of Jerusalem:]
 6:13a Return, return O Shulammite!
 6:13b Return, return, that we may gaze upon you!
 [Husband, to Daughters of Jerusalem:]
 6:13c Do not gaze upon the Shulammite,
 6:13d As on the *Machanayim* Dance!
 [Husband, to wife:]
 7:1a How beautiful are your feet in sandals, princess!

7:1b Your thighs are like *chala'im*,
 7:1c The work of a [true] craftsman's hands.
 7:2a Your navel is a rounded bowl—
 7:2b May it never lack mixed wine!
 7:2c Your belly is a mound of wheat,
 7:2d Surrounded by asphodels.
 7:3a Your two breasts are like two fawns,
 7:3b Twins of a gazelle.
 7:4a Your neck is like an ivory tower.
 7:4b Your eyes are wells in Heshbon,
 7:4c By the Bathrabbim Gate.
 7:4d Your nose is like the tower of Lebanon,
 7:4e Looking toward Damascus.
 7:5a Your head is like Carmel,
 7:5b And the hair of your head is like purple—
 7:5c The king is held captive in your tresses!
 7:6a How beautiful and how pleasant you are,
 7:6b O beloved who is so delightful!
 7:7a Your stature is like a date-palm tree,
 7:7b And your breasts [are] like clusters [of dates].
 7:8a I think to myself, "I will climb the date-palm tree;
 7:8b I will take hold of the fronds"—
 7:8c And may your breasts be like clusters of the grape vine,
 7:8d And [may] the fragrance of your breath [be] like apples,
 7:9a And [may] your mouth [be] like the best wine...
 [Wife, to/of husband:]
 7:9b ...Flowing smoothly for my beloved,
 7:9c Gliding over the lips of the sleepers!
 7:10a I am my beloved's,
 7:10b And his desire is for me.
 7:11a Come, my beloved, let us go into the fields,
 7:11b Let us spend the night among the henna plants.
 7:12a Let us arise early and go to the vineyards—
 7:12b Let us see whether the vine has sprouted,
 7:12c [And whether] the young fruit has bloomed,
 7:12d [And whether] the pomegranates have budded.
 7:12e There I will give you my love.
 7:13a The mandrakes have given forth their fragrance,
 7:13b And on our doorway is every excellent thing,
 7:13c [Both] new and old,
 7:13d Which I have stored up for you, my beloved.
 8:1a Oh, how I wish that that you were my brother,
 8:1b Who had nursed at the breasts of my mother:
 8:1c [Then] I would find you outside, [and] I would kiss you,
 8:1d And no one would despise me either.
 8:2a [Then] I would lead you to the house of my mother who reared me;
 8:2b I would give you spiced wine to drink,
 8:2c [And] pomegranate must.
 8:3a Let his left hand be under my head,
 8:3b And his right hand embrace me!
 8:4a I adjure you, Daughters of Jerusalem,
 8:4b Not to stir up or awaken love
 8:4c Until it pleases.

[Daughters of Jerusalem, concerning the wife:]

8:5a Who is this coming up from the desert,

8:5b Leaning on her beloved?

[Wife:]

8:5c Under the apple tree I aroused you—

8:5d There your mother was in labor with you;

8:5e There she who gave you birth was in labor [with you].

8:6a Place me like a seal on your heart,

8:6b Like a seal on your arm.

8:6c For love is as strong as death;

8:6d Passion is as powerful as Sheol;

8:6e Its tendrils—tendrils of fire are its flames.

8:7a A mighty torrent cannot quench love,

8:7b Nor can rivers sweep it away.

8:7c If a man were to sell all the treasures of his household for love,

8:7d People would utterly despise him.

8:8- [In my youth my brothers thought to themselves,]

8:8a “We have a little sister,

8:8b “And she does not [yet] have breasts;

8:8c “What will we do for our sister

8:8d “On the day when someone asks to marry her?”

8:9a “If she is a wall,

8:9b “We will build for her a silver battlement;

8:9c “But if she is a door,

8:9d “We will build for her a cedar plank.”

8:10a I was a wall, and my breasts were like towers;

8:10b Then I was in his eyes like one who finds peace.

8:11a Solomon had a vineyard in Baal-Hamon.

8:11b He leased the vineyard to keepers;

8:11c Each man would generate a thousand silver with its fruit.

8:12a My vineyard is mine to do with as I wish.

8:12b You keep the thousand, Solomon,

8:12c And let the [vineyard-]keepers have the two hundred.

[Husband:]

8:13a You who dwell in the gardens,

8:13b [My] friends are listening [to the sound of your voice],

8:13c [But] let me be the one to hear your voice!

[Wife:]

8:14a Pass on, my beloved, and be like a gazelle,

8:14b Or like the young [and strong] offspring of the deer

8:14c On the mountains of balsam.

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